The Queen's Proxy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37355962.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M, Gen

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Characters:
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Additional Tags:
Established Relationship, catradora, Post-Canon, Post-Season/Series 05, Catra in charge of things again, struggles against the bureaucratic machine: a cautionary tale, Catra's done plenty of therapy already, there's a sassy tailor, and two brothers that argue about taxes enough it becomes a problem, Catra never gets sick, Royal Advisor Catra

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The Queen's Proxy

by TelenNarre

Summary

The idea was to stay home and rest, pig out on all the food in the castle's larder, and maybe even find new hiding spots to scare Adora from when her and Bow came back from yet another space adventure. Catra hadn't counted on Glimmer, who had also chosen to stay home, getting sick.

With her down and out, the backlog of queenly duties she was supposed to take care of wouldn't get done—not unless Catra decided to step up. She'd learned how to do all her paperwork as second in command in the Horde, purely out of spite, because of how Shadow Weaver had talked down to her like one would a child when she went to her for advice.

Running a kingdom was no different. How hard could it be?

OR

A humorous tale of Catra's fight against bureaucratic inefficiency, the 'holier-than-thou' attitude of a minor aristocracy from neighboring lands, and a lot of Bright Moon guards. Like, a whole graduating cohort of them.

(Post season 5. Catra-centric)

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> This one I wrote as a brain-dump self-indulgence decompression piece after finishing the 4th draft of World Eater.
>
> It took me longer to revise and edit than I'd anticipated (3-4 weeks-ish instead of 1). But that means this fic, like the other two I've posted/been posting, is fully done before the first chapter even goes up :)
>
> I have to look into what time I can carve out for final proof reads, but you can expect regular updates until completion. Either weekly or every other week.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had expected to wake up that first morning back in Bright Moon and feel depressed Adora wasn't there with her in their shared bed.

Six months had passed since Horde Prime's defeat, and Catra and Adora had spent those six months glued at the hip, traveling space together, visiting worlds, bringing back magic to a galaxy with a sudden and glaring power vacuum. Bow and Glimmer had been there too, but that was beside the point.

The point was, when Glimmer had announced she was staying behind after their next pit stop home to take care of her queenly duties that had piled on in the interim, Catra had also elected to stay, citing her newly appointed position as Glimmer's "chief advisor" as well as a desire to decompress from a long stint in space and on alien worlds. Adora chose to continue traveling with Bow (and Melog and Micah), and Catra had expected to feel loss at their separation, like some great piece of her was suddenly missing.

She didn’t feel lost, and she didn’t feel like any part of her was missing. At least, not so far. She didn’t quite trust herself, yet.

Catra waited until her morning routine was complete for her emotions to settle. She peeled herself out of bed, bathed with Bright Moon’s special foaming bath bombs she refused to admit to anyone she liked, brushed her teeth and her hair, and only when she had gotten through that and had started down the hall and toward the kitchens did she finally admit to herself: she missed Adora, yes, but it was a healthy sort of longing. She wasn’t suddenly an incomplete version of herself now that Adora was gone—a feeling she had wrestled with during their entire adolescence and especially during their schism after Adora had defected.

Maybe Perfuma was right in saying Catra was growing into a more stable and well-adjusted person than she gave herself credit for.

Deep in thought as she was, it took Catra a moment to realize the castle hallways were empty, and eerily so. It wasn’t until she pushed through the doors into the kitchens that she saw another person: a single cook, white apron complimenting their tall chef’s hat. They were stirring a waist-height pot of soup sitting atop a burner set into the floor tiling.

“Hey, has Glimmer come through already?” Catra asked, threading around the large center kitchen island and its single-slabbed marble surface toward them.

“Haven’t run into the queen yet,” the cook said, shaking their head. “You’re the first person I’ve seen since starting my shift. The night crew prepped breakfast for the guards, so I’ve had very little to do.” They stopped stirring and placed the giant wooden spoon they were using flat across the top of the pot. “Want me to fix you anything?”

Half an hour later and Catra sat at the head of the massive long table in the castle’s dining sanctum, chewing absentmindedly on

breakfast sausage and sipping decaffeinated coffee. One of the two guards stationed at the dining room entrance, fully armored and holding pikes, coughed, and the sound echoed. Rays of light beamed through the tall windows, illuminating the specks of dust as they floating about. When Catra sat back in the chair, it creaked, and she winced at how loud that sounded against the silence.

Geeze, she thought, her tail thumping an irate rhythm against the side of the chair. *Sparkles mentioned now would be a good time for her to stay behind too because of how slow everything got in the kingdom around this time, but I didn't think it'd be like this.*

Without Adora or Bow, the castle just felt so damn *empty*.

Catra had specifically chosen the spot at the head of the table to get a rise out of Glimmer when she inevitably walked in. That seat was reserved for the queen, and although Catra knew Glimmer wouldn't really be upset at her for stealing her chair, she also knew it would push all of her territorial buttons and be supremely entertaining. But for Catra to get even that small amount of entertainment out of the morning, Glimmer would have to show up first, and she was running more than just a little late so far.

"How the hell is she supposed to get to all her little duties that have piled up if she doesn't even wake up at a decent time to eat breakfast?" Catra said, under her breath and more to herself than anything.

After breakfast (and after fighting off the cook, who balked at her desire to wash up her own dish instead of letting him do it), Catra went to personally hunt down the queen. She was her official chief advisor, after all, and it wasn't just an informal title bestowed because of their friendship. At least, Catra hoped it wasn't. Glimmer had given her the position about a month after Prime's defeat, and the memory of that moment was something she cherished deeply.

"Sparkles, are you still asleep?" she asked, pounding on the high double doors of Glimmer's room hard enough it made the metal hinges rattle. "I'm giving you five seconds to tell me not to come in before I do, and I *swear* you better fucking warn me in those five seconds if you aren't decent. I still have nightmares about the last time I walked in on you and Bow, and even though he's not here I *really* don't need to see any more of you than I'm already used to."

Two more guards were at the door with her, and one of them tried and failed to stifle a laugh. The other shot them a stern look in response and shook their head. Catra smirked and winked at them both. She counted to three instead of five, then kicked open the doors open with so much force they slammed into the inside walls of the bedroom.

Glimmer screamed and shot upright in bed, the blankets pooling around her hips, her hair sticking out in too many directions. Thankfully, she was wearing a shirt—one of Bow's oversized crew necks if the archery graphic and "I can make you quiver" text was anything to go by—so Catra didn't get an eyeful.

"Catra, what the *hell* are you doing?"

"The entire trip home, you wouldn't shut up about all the stuff you had to catch up on this week," Catra said, pushing further into the room to stand at Glimmer's bedside. She put her hands on her hips and stared down at her friend. "It's the whole reason you stayed behind to begin with. I figured I'd better come wake you up since you haven't done shit and its already almost *noon*."

Glimmer's eyes blew wide and she squawked, twisting against the sheets to look at the clock on her nightstand. It read just past nine in the morning and Glimmer, after breathing a sigh of relief, turned back to fix Catra with a murderous glare.

Catra folded her arms. "Well, you're still late anyways. And it *would* have been almost noon eventually if I hadn't come and woken you up, so, you're welcome."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Well, since someone was so kind as to make sure I’m wide awake now, I might as well get to it.”

She threw her covers off and moved to get out of bed, but something just seemed off. Catra watched her through narrowed eyes and stopped her when her bare feet touched the carpet.

Glimmer startled. “What are you—”

Catra pressed the back of her hand to Glimmer’s forehead and then pulled away like she had touched a hot stove, a curse and a hiss escaping her.

“You have a fever,” she said, her fangs peeking out a moment when the ghost of a snarl accompanied her words. “You’re sick.”

Glimmer shook her head, but the sheepish look on her face betrayed her. “No, I’m fine I promise. Sometimes I wake up hot is all.”

“Bullshit. You’re *always* on time for breakfast. You take your duties as queen more seriously than any of the other princesses except Frosta, even when we’re off world.” Catra leaned down into Glimmer’s space and scrutinized her. “Tell me you weren’t sleeping in to try and feel better before you started on everything.”

“I wasn’t, I swear. I was just—”

“You got any chills? Any sore muscles? Sore throat? Cough?”

Growing up in the Horde, Catra was used to steamrolling sick people and forcing them to rest. Firstly, because Adora in particular was as bullheaded as they came and would always try to push through it, and secondly because it would pull everyone else on the team’s score down during their training exercises for the day. And that often meant Shadow Weaver would come down on them, hardest of all on Catra even though she was the one that almost never got sick herself.

"I'm *fine*," Glimmer said, shooting her a scowl that looked more like a pained expression of suffering than anything threatening. "No chills, nothing sore, no cough. I'm good."

As if fate decided to be cruel to someone other than Catra for once, Glimmer shivered and shuddered from a chill the moment she finished speaking, descended into a fit of terrible, whooping coughs, then clutched at her head and moaned in pain once it was all done.

She was dead sick.

"Okay, you're not leaving this bed until you're fully rested up," Catra said. She squatted down and lifted both Glimmer's feet off the floor, shoving them back onto the bed and working the blankets back over her until she was firmly tucked in again. "Is there like, some sort of nanny team or whatever that comes in and takes care of royalty when they're bedridden or something?" She snapped her fingers and pointed a finger gun at Glimmer. "Hospice, right?"

Glimmer snorted with laughter then immediately gasped in pain. Catra would have made fun of the dumb expression on her face if she weren't so intent on mothering her friend.

"Hospice is for dying people, Catra," Glimmer said. "Where the heck did you get the idea that's what they were called?"

Catra shrugged. "Dunno, just heard it somewhere. No one took care of us in the Horde so I didn't even know a job caring for sick people was a thing, let alone having a word for it."

"*Nurse* is the word you're looking for. And we do have nurses. They'd take care of me if it was really serious, but it's not." Glimmer moved to get out of the bed again, but Catra shot her a death glare and she stilled. "Seriously, I do have things I need to take care of and I'm not really that sick. I'll be fine, just let me—"

Yet another coughing spell overcame her, and Glimmer grabbed at her head again when it subsided. Catra reasoned she had a

terrible headache that got worse every time that happened.

"Yeah, no," Catra said, already turning and stalking back to the guards still by the door. "I'll call your nurses or whatever and they can make the final say on whether or not you're good. And when they say there's no way in hell you're getting out of bed, we'll talk about how to take care of all your chores that have piled up too."

The verdict came even faster than Catra had anticipated: Glimmer wasn't getting out of that bed, and she looked like she wanted to strangle the head nurse for having made the decision. Catra tried not to feel too smug about it.

"Give me twenty minutes with her or something," Catra said to the nurse. "We've gotta figure out what to do with the agenda she had for the next few days since she won't be able to get to it. Then she's all yours."

The nurse gave Catra a 'sisters in arms' look of comradery and a nod. Glimmer was notoriously hard-headed, and Catra had a feeling the nurse understood she had a long, uphill battle coming trying to force Glimmer to rest.

Still, she ushered her team out the bedroom to give them privacy. When the door shut behind them with a click, Glimmer turned her icy glare on Catra.

"I hate you," she said. "You know that, right?"

"Is that why you always fight with Melog for the sleep spot next to me when we camp on alien worlds?" Catra smirked at Glimmer, with teeth. "That's because you hate me, right?"

Glimmer groused, tingeing pink. "You are like a *furnace*, and Bow is like an ice cube. There's no way I'm fighting Adora for her spot, so it has to be Melog. And I hate camping." She pressed her head further back into her pillow with a groan. "I actually have stuff to do this week though! I'm seriously not even that bad. I would have been able to suffer through it if you hadn't dragged the

nurse in here. Now all the stuff I specifically stayed behind for is going to just get pushed back even further."

Catra shrugged. "Why don't I take care of it for you?"

"Hah, funny joke. *You* want to run the kingdom until I get better?"

"I mean, not particularly. But you're sick and this stuff is important. I don't mind helping out." Catra fought hard to keep her tail from thrashing or her ears from pinning. Truth be told, she did want to do this for Glimmer, but didn't want to seem like she cared so damn much. It was a thin line to walk.

"I don't think you understand what you're offering," Glimmer said. "There are rules and decorum. Paperwork. Meetings with tons of people you have to talk to. People who make you want to leap over a table and strangle them because they keep saying 'uhm' every third word and you just can't take it anymore, but you *have* to play nice with them or else they'll pull funding for a major water pipeline and everyone will hate you forever because of it."

"Sounds like a pain in the ass, yep," Catra said nodding, before furrowing her brow. "And that last one seems suspiciously specific."

"Not if it happens so regularly. I could probably track the changes of the seasons by counting how many weeks have passed since I last spoke with that particular person in question."

"Right," Catra said, drawing out the vowel. "So where exactly do I start?"

Now it was Glimmer's turn to scrutinize Catra. "You're serious about this? You aren't joking about wanting to take over my duties while I'm recuperating?"

Catra tried her best not to shy away or stutter. "Yeah, I'm serious. I'm your official chief advisor, right? Unless you gave me that title for literally no reason?"

"No, I didn't just—" Glimmer shook her head. "Of course you're my advisor Catra. I just thought we'd, you know, take baby steps. Have you shadow me on things like I did with my mom, and eventually tag team some of my duties before handing them off. I didn't think you'd whole-hog it and dive right into the deep end the second I couldn't perform."

Catra rolled her eyes and scoffed to mask just how relieved she felt to hear Glimmer say she really was her advisor because, truthfully, she halfway *was* expecting her to say the title was just a formality.

"Okay, maybe you and I haven't been properly introduced," Catra said, leaning into the teasing in her voice. "I'm Catra. I dive head-first into everything and anything, including trying to conquer your kingdom before we became friends. If you have any complaints, please lodge them with the current She Ra of Etheria, because I'm certain she's the one that rubbed that particular trait off on me when we were kids."

"I'll be sure to take it up with her as soon as she comes back," Glimmer said, between grit teeth. When she turned her attention off to the side, Catra followed her gaze and saw a massive calendar pasted to the far wall of the bedroom.

"They really packed you tight, didn't they?" Catra asked, looking over how much of the current week was highlighted in bright pink, and a flowery, cursive, bolded script on top of it read 'Glimmer is back!!!' Every other week on the calendar was empty because they had been off-planet, dealing with some other magic-related issue in the galaxy.

"My staff misses me when I'm gone," Glimmer said, fondness seeping into her tone. "So yeah, they've taken to updating my calendar and packing as many things as they can for me while I'm around." She frowned. "Except that just means I can't actually tell what I'm supposed to do when I *do* see the itinerary, because they've crammed the boxes so full of sticky notes you can't actually read what the tasks are."

It was true. Underneath the highlighted portion for the week were a monstrous number of sticky notes pasted all across, each note likely containing whatever task or appointment was booked for that day and time. That strip of calendar looked almost like a feathered creature with how the notes piled on top of one another and jutted out at odd angles, fighting to stay affixed. The last day of the week had a bright yellow star drawn around it in marker with the words 'Master Bow, Princess Adora, and King Emeritus Micah come home!' Catra chuckled at the 'Princess' title next to Adora's name.

Speaking of Micah, Catra had forgotten he'd decided to travel to space this time, since Glimmer was staying behind. He hadn't gotten the chance to explore yet, and everyone had encouraged him to go with Adora, Bow, and Melog on their next adventure.

"Just out of curiosity," Catra said, pulling Glimmer's attention back. "Why doesn't your dad help out with some of this stuff while you're gone? You might not have such a hugely clusterfucked pile of duties to attend to when you come back if he did some of them."

Glimmer laughed. "He does, Catra. He takes care of most of the important things still, actually, on top of traveling to the other kingdoms and advising the other princesses. Everything you see there is stuff he either didn't get to yet, or things he specifically left for me because they really should be done by the current queen and not the retired king."

Catra's eyes bugged out of her head and she took another look at the calendar. That was what was left behind after Micah did everything else?

"Alright," she said after swallowing. "Well, I'm still serious about helping. Just point me to a good place to start and I'll take it from there?"

Glimmer studied her a moment longer before nodding and pointing past Catra. "Can you bring me that thing sitting on the

dresser behind you?”

A tablet computer was sitting upright in its charging dock on the dresser, decorated with rhinestones on the back and an obnoxious pink color-scheme throughout. Catra grabbed it and made a face as she handed it over, making Glimmer giggle.

“I asked my people to start using the tools Entrapta made for all of us to help run the kingdoms a little more efficiently,” she said. “I’m hoping they at least figured out how to use the calendaring app. Let me just—” Glimmer swiped and tapped at the screen, brow knit in concentration as she bit at her lip. “Yessss they put it in for me, thank god.”

When she handed the device back, Catra saw the same calendar on the wall now displayed on the screen, but each of the dozens of appointments were now clearly visible, and many of them had been grayed out.

“I deselected the ones that aren’t super pressing,” Glimmer said as Catra perused. “Everything that still pops out at you are the things that would really, *really* suck if we had to push back.”

“First thing is a four-hour long paperwork block starting ten minutes ago,” Catra said, looking at the first item. “Nothing in the afternoon or evening. You cleared it all out?”

“You’ll need to get fitted to hold court tomorrow morning, so that time needs to be free.”

“Fitted?” Catra looked up from the device at Glimmer and felt her hair start to stand on end when she saw the look of devilish glee on Glimmer’s face.

“Yes, fitted,” she said. “There’s not a chance in hell Sasha is going to let you sit on the throne without getting his hands on you first, royal proxy or no. As soon as I send word out that you’ll be taking over, I know he’s going to take up everything after lunch. That’s why I cleared it out.”

Catra raised a brow at her. She hadn't expected needing a new wardrobe, but dressing up for Princess Prom was sort of fun. She didn't know why Glimmer was getting so giddy about it, though, and she'd likely not find out before the day was up. Catra resolved to stay alert for any funny business or pranks.

"Then after that's done," Catra said, "I hold court tomorrow morning until lunch, then after lunch is prepping to host some sort of special dinner?"

Glimmer's expression turned serious. "That's the important one I was freaking out about missing," she said. "It's not *really* a huge deal—a minor noble family from the surrounding area, is coming. We've rescheduled with them twice already while I was out, so having to do it again would have been…painful."

"Won't they be pissed it's me that will be with them instead of you, still?"

"Yeah," Glimmer said, nodding. "But having it with you is better than not having it at all or having to reschedule. They might not be getting the queen of Bright Moon, but they'll be getting her closest advisor, not to mention She Ra's girlfriend." Glimmer winked at her. "I think they'll be satisfied with that. They provide a good portion of our meat and animal product import, so we need to keep a good relationship with them."

Catra nodded and pressed her lips into a thin line. Glimmer's compliment had flustered her and she needed to take a moment. Entertaining guests was never her forte, either, but she'd do her best.

"Day after that is a speech and, after lunch"—she squinted at the last box—"an afternoon for…miscellaneous?"

"There's usually a lot of really, *really* minor things that stack up too. They take, like, a minute or two individually to address, but they pile up. My staff usually just cram as much of it as they can into one afternoon block and I knock it all out in one go. It'll be

more mind numbing than challenging, I think, and they'll appreciate you for taking care of it."

Catra nodded. "Let's rewind to the speech, though. I'm supposed to talk at a ceremony at Bright Moon's guard academy?"

"That one I'm kind of jealous you'll get to do in my stead, actually. It's a graduation speech for the cohort that finished there this semester. I'm sure you'll think of something inspiring to tell them."

Catra lowered the tablet again and peered at Glimmer with a skeptical look. "Do they know I almost conquered your kingdom not too long ago?"

Glimmer shrugged. "Probably. But even if they do, I know they'll want to hear what you have to say. You're a member of my court now, remember? It's your kingdom too. Plus it will be good for your image, since it will be a chance for them to see and hear from you first-hand."

Catra sighed and nodded, looking away. The people of Bright Moon were still wary of her, that much was common knowledge. Even if she was in Glimmer's inner circle and technically a member of the royal court, everyone seemed to remember she was ex-Horde who nearly overran their home wholesale. Glimmer was giving her a chance to help defray some of those hurt feelings little by little, and she was grateful for it.

That didn't stop her from still feeling terrified about it, though.

"And if that all crashes and burns and goes to shit," Catra said, forcing levity into her voice, "then at least Adora and Bow both come back that evening." She looked to the physical calendar again and the yellow star drawn there, marking their friends' return.

Glimmer shot her a grin. "That's the spirit."

"Okay." Catra swallowed and nodded. "Okay, sure, this is fine. I'll start with the paperwork, then. Can you uh…tell me where to go

for that? And I can piggyback off of whoever is there to help get me to the next thing."

The look of unadulterated appreciation that bloomed on Glimmer's face made Catra flush and sent her tail flicking erratically, low to the ground.

"You'll want the study next to the dining room," she said. "And the fact no one has come to break my door down for being late tells me the nurse gave them a heads up." Glimmer gestured back to her nightstand. "You'll need one more thing before you go though. Check the drawer for my signet ring."

Catra shuffled over to the nightstand, pulled open the drawer, and nearly shut it with force when she saw what was inside.

"What is it?" Glimmer asked, confusion flitting across her features. "Is the ring not in there?"

Catra opened the drawer again and pulled out a bought-in-bulk package of contraceptives from inside, quirking an eyebrow at Glimmer when she angled the box toward her.

Glimmer's face when scarlet, same as Catra's. "Uhm, well, you know it's been months since we've been back," she said. "I haven't checked inside that drawer since then. It's not like we…I mean, we just use it for…well…uh…"

Catra shook her head and put the box back in the drawer as quick as she could. "Yep, all good. You don't need to explain it to me, I got it." Heaven forbid Glimmer ever stumble upon her and Adora's private things. If Catra was this flustered herself over something admittedly not even that risqué, she couldn't bear to imagine how she'd respond if their situations were reversed.

She saw the signet ring and fished it out, shutting the drawer again quickly with a bump of her hip. "This is it, right?" she asked, showing Glimmer.

Glimmer nodded, still red in the face, and cleared her throat. "That ring officially vests you with the authority to do stuff on my behalf. The staff will know what you're there for when they see it on you."

Catra slid it on her index finger and shuffled around the bed, positioning herself for a quick exit. She was starting to get emotional over this, and it wasn't just that awkward moment from earlier that had tilted her off balance.

"I'll get to it then. You just focus on resting up, yeah?"

"Catra."

She stopped in her tracks halfway to the exit, rooted to the spot by how suddenly sincere Glimmer's tone of voice was. She looked back over her shoulder.

"Are you sure about doing this?" Glimmer asked. "You're certain you want to take this on while I just stay in bed?"

Catra nodded. "Yes, I'm sure. Thank you for, y'know…trusting me enough to hand over this much, I guess. I'll try and visit you when I have a free moment or two, maybe during lunch. It will probably get insanely lonely being cooped up in this room all day."

"Won't you get sick too if you spend too much time around me?"

Now that was a question Catra could latch onto and deflect all her other emotions with. She smiled wide and gave a cocky shrug. "Nah. My physiology is different from yours, remember? Besides, I'm pretty sure I can count with one hand how many times I've been sick and still have at least one finger in particular left over I can use to flip you off when you annoy me."

That got an outright laugh from Glimmer and Catra smiled wider in response. "Thank you," she said. "Really."

Catra nodded. "Don't mention it."

With that, Catra left out the door, letting the team of nurses still waiting on the other side file in after her to pamper and fuss over the queen. She set her shoulders, took a deep, confidence-boosting breath, and headed down the hall to the study. There was likely a mountain of Glimmer's paperwork waiting for her to sift through, and although paperwork was the last thing she'd ever *want* to do with her free time, Glimmer trusted her enough to hand it off entirely when she couldn't get to it.

Catra wouldn't let her down.

Chapter End Notes

> Something about the scene where Catra deposes Shadow Weaver and then goes to her for advice about paperwork was really funny to me. And so I wrote an entire multichapter fic centered wholly around Catra finding herself in all sorts of humorous, overly bureaucratic, asinine situations. All because she was in charge of something again.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The study was far worse than Catra had imagined on the walk over. It sat between the library and the castle's massive dining hall, so she didn't need directions or a guide. But while she had been inside each of those other two places—the dining hall and especially the kitchen near it on more occasions than she'd care to admit—she'd never had cause to visit the castle's study before.

A study just meant a smaller, cozier library, right? Instead, she found paper Armageddon.

Books, magazines, reams of paper, cardstock, and other stationery littered not just the few open table spaces before her, but were also stacked *vertically* like parapets and skyscrapers. Less organized junk was thrown together in clumps—paper, manila folders, and cardboard boxes filled with more papers and manila folders. There was only one, single path of tiled flooring underfoot, snaking around and between the clumps and skyscrapers and parapets, to a desk which was thankfully clear of anything except a single dip pen resting in an inkwell.

Feeling uncharacteristically nervous and bewildered, Catra threaded through the pathway toward the desk. 'Paperwork' just sounded boring and tedious, so why did this feel like an impending ordeal? None of the other parts of the castle were this cluttered. What was going on?

A young woman wearing glasses and a puffy-sleeved blouse that tucked into her pants rounded the corner just as Catra reached the desk. Catra screamed, then the woman screamed and nearly threw the stack of papers and books she was carrying at Catra out of panic.

“Holy shit.” Catra caught her breath, doubled over with one hand on the desk to brace herself. Gradually, her fur settled down and lay flat against her body again. “You scared the crap out of me!”

“I’m so, *so*, sorry,” the woman said, quickly putting her papers and books down on the desk next to the inkwell. Catra guessed they were close to the same age. “I would have said something if I knew you’d come in, but I didn’t even hear the door open.”

“Yeah, I didn’t hear you either, and that’s saying something.” Catra looked down at her hand, her extended claws already digging into and scratching the (likely expensive) wood of the table. She consciously retracted them. “I almost clawed your face right off without even thinking about it.”

The woman gulped and cleared her throat. “Thank you for not doing that,” she said, before smoothing down the front of her outfit. Catra noticed she refused to look her in the eyes, and seemed painfully shy.

Maybe it was a blessing in disguise Melog decided not to stay behind either, she thought. Catra held back a chuckle, imagining just how much worse the woman’s reaction might have been if Melog had turned spiky and red after feeding off Catra’s surprise.

“Uhm…” the woman said, voice painfully small. “Can…can I help you with something? Were you looking for a different room, maybe?”

“No, I’m here to sub in for the queen.”

That got a reaction. She finally looked up and met Catra’s gaze, before her entire face turned red and her eyes went wide. Catra held up her hand to show the signet ring.

“Glimmer is useless,” she said. “She needs to stay in bed because she’s sick. She sent me in her place to take care of the important stuff on the calendar this week.”

“The queen is…sick?” Confusion flickered across the woman’s face and she bit her lip. She still didn’t understand.

It was no wonder there wasn’t anybody banging down Glimmer’s bedroom door for being late to her duties if this is who was supposedly waiting on her. Catra found it hard to imagine her even knocking politely to find out what had happened, and by the apparent state of the room, Glimmer might have been shirking her paperwork for longer than just a few months.

“You didn’t get like a notification?” Catra asked. “I watched her rearrange her schedule on her tablet. Shouldn’t there have been some sort of message or something informing you about the change? I can’t imagine there not being a way of keeping tabs on the queen’s schedule if it needs to be shifted around last minute.”

The woman’s eyes widened in surprise behind her glasses. Instead of helping clarify, Catra had seemed to only startle her further.

“Oh…oh *shoot* I didn’t even check the—” she darted around Catra to a computer terminal, wedged into a far corner among even more books. Catra watched her hunt and peck on the machine’s keyboard, cursing and grumbling under her breath. Before long, Catra realized she was trying (and failing) to bring up the same calendar schedule Glimmer had showed her moments before.

“It’s that one over there,” Catra said, already at her side, pointing at the icon that would open the calendar.

The woman stiffened (seriously, just how jumpy was she?) and nodded before clicking the icon Catra pointed out. As expected, the calendar appeared, as did all the changes Glimmer had made minutes ago. A notification to ‘all staff’ that informed them of Catra assuming proxy duties for the week popped up too.

It all seemed so straightforward, but when Catra glanced sidelong at the woman, she saw more confusion and barely concealed panic in her expression as she stared at the screen.

Catra pressed her lips together and breathed through her nose. It was going to be a long day.

Her name was Elmira, and despite her initial impression, Catra came to learn she was as quick a learner as she was shy.

No one had explained the computer to her or how to use it, and she had been so busy in the months since it had first been installed, she'd never had time to learn it herself. Catra walked her through the basics—how to click things, how to use basic software, how to look up information when she didn't know how to do something—and Elmira was infinitely grateful. Unfortunately, that ate about an hour of the morning paperwork block she was already late for to begin with, so when Catra finally sat at the desk ready to get some work done, she was even further behind schedule.

And if that weren't a big enough dampener on her start as proxy to the queen, the paperwork itself was far, *far* more mind numbing than even the wildest, most masochistic parts of her psyche could imagine. The "four-hour paperwork block," as had been marked out in the calendar, consisted of Catra sitting at the desk, reading a document from the stacks Elmira kept placing on said desk, signing her name, then stamping the document with the royal seal if she didn't notice anything remiss.

Maybe that would have been entertaining enough to focus on had the contents of the documents themselves been of any interest, but the universe couldn't even give Catra that much. Two solid working hours later, now toward the end of the calendared time, and Catra had perused, scanned, skimmed, and speed-read through endless sheets of paper that recorded everything from perfunctory responses to inquiries about Bright Moon's water treatment procedures from neighboring counties, to acknowledging the births, marriages, and various anniversaries of the kingdom's inhabitants

“It just really makes their day”, was Elmira’s response when Catra asked why the hell she was stamping letters like that. She’d even signed off on a fifty-page, collated list of people visiting the kingdom the prior Thursday afternoon. That last one Catra initially assumed to be some kind of cargo manifest for goods flowing in and out of a nearby port. She nearly flung the stack of papers away in irritated rage when she realized they were names of people—*just* people—entering and leaving through the front gates.

When she got through that and the next three stacks of paper, Elmira placed yet another on her desk. It was a backlog of all the queen’s fan mail from her subjects.

“I told you they enjoy hearing from her,” Elmira said, when Catra asked about it. “They *like* getting letters from Queen Glimmer on stuff like marriages or anniversaries, even if it’s just a template with her signature on it. They know she takes the time to sign them, and they know if they send her a letter, they’ll get a response.”

“She seriously responds to every single one? By hand?” Catra’s tone came out more like a whine, even to herself. She wasn’t jealous of Glimmer’s admirers, and she wasn’t slightly hurt that everyone in the kingdom seemed to still side-eye her. Having to sign and stamp all of Glimmer’s freaking fan mail definitely wasn’t triggering any sort of emotions in her, nope.

Elmira laughed—a subtle thing that seemed more for her own benefit than anyone else’s. “There’s a template for most responses too, which is what I’ve been giving you to sign. The important, personal ones I’ve put aside for her to look at and respond to herself.”

That only further dampened Catra’s spirits. Could she defray some of the citizenry’s hurt feelings about her if she started writing them letters too? Would that be weird?

Yeah, that’d probably be weird.

Catra pressed her lips together, murmured something noncommittal to herself, and got to stamping. She didn't actually read the mail or the canned responses she was signing. She didn't think her ego could take the bruising and she wasn't that much of a masochist.

Finally, she finished and mentally patted herself on the back for it. That one stack of documents alone likely would have been more than enough to send her self-esteem plummeting to new depths for the whole day if she hadn't exercised restraint.

And when she immediately pulled a page from the next stack of papers, ready and eager to move on only to find the document she was about to stamp was the most useless waste of her time out of everything she had stamped thus far, she snapped.

"Is this really necessary?" Catra asked. She peered up at Elmira from her seat, only to nearly backtrack and apologize on the spot at seeing how Elmira flinched at her words. Catra's aggravation had seeped into her tone—it had come out too abrasive.

"Is…is what, necessary, Your Eminence?"Catra resisted the urge to hiss and, instead, closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and rubbed her temples. She had asked Elmira to call her by her name several times now since helping her with the computer, and while Elmira never outright refused to do so, she always ended up using the 'Your Eminence' honorific anyways. Catra hated it.

"Okay, first of all," she said. "We've been over this. My name is Catra, not 'Your Eminence'"—she held up a hand to stop Elmira from interrupting her, before gesturing to the new stack of papers on the—"and second of all, *what* is with this thing I'm supposed to sign? This first page is just requesting approval on the design of another royal seal. That's what I'm supposed to sit at the desk and look at? Are there really no documents more important to sign than that?"

She picked up the offending report in question and waved it around. "I thought reviewing the names of the hundreds of

people coming and leaving the kingdom was bad enough, now I'm supposed to read that there is a new royal stamp design and, what? Stamp it? With the *current* royal stamp? What's wrong with the one we already have?"

"Nothing is wrong, Your Emin—er, Catra, Ma'am. But the seal you are using is that of the late queen, Angella. Queen Glimmer wanted her own made. This is the finalized design."

Silence fell between them, heavy with implication. Catra let out another deep breath and nodded, before handing the document over.

"Save this for her eyes, then," she said. "Glimmer should have final say on the design, not me."

Elmira nodded and wordlessly took the paper.

"I'm guessing the rest of these are just as important?" Catra asked, gesturing with a tilt of her head to the rest of the stack. "Just like that one?"

Elmira cleared her throat and started and stopped a half dozen sentences; already not a good sign. Catra peeled the next sheet of the top of the stack and looked through it.

It was another list of people who had come and gone from Bright Moon, but from last Wednesday this time instead of last Thursday. Elmira grimaced, and that grimace only deepened as Catra leafed through the stack to find it was full of more of the same: transit logs reaching back at least a month.

"Look," Catra said, getting ahead of Elmira before she could say anything and trying to keep her voice as level as possible. "Glimmer has more important things to do than read who comes and goes through the kingdom walls all day. Hell, *I* have better things to do than look at them, and before volunteering to be proxy, my schedule for the week consisted of napping, pigging out in the pantry, and finding new places to jump scare Adora from in the castle when she gets back."

Elmira blinked at her, the tinges of fear playing against her features. Catra didn't want to scare her. Was Elmira just easily startled, or was she just easily startled *by Catra* specifically?

"The change in schedule came through electronically the minute it was decided I was going to take over," Catra said. "But you didn't see it or even know how to work the computer until I showed you. And from the giant physical calendar still bursting full of sticky notes in Glimmer's room, I get the impression it isn't just you who's got no clue how to use the terminals."

Catra paused and studied Elmira. The other girl swallowed, and as far as Catra was concerned, that was enough to confirm her suspicions.

"Entrapta has spent the last few months after Prime's defeat helping modernize the other kingdoms," Catra said. "We had to promise to give her Darla for a whole month once Adora and Bow and Micah all get back this time before she agreed to do it. Heck, she even coded most of Frosta's princess duties into a virtual reality *video game* for crying out loud. She takes care of official paperwork by punching zombies in the face with ice fists.

"*Please* tell me why all the other kingdoms are so far ahead, and Glimmer is still stuck using paper notes, paper memos, paper calendars, paper documents, official stamps for those paper documents, and paper everything else?" She gestured to the wider study and all of the stationery and books before saying, "you can't even *see* two feet in front of you because there's so much paper everywhere."

Elmira looked like she wanted to be crawl under a rock, and Catra just wanted to give her a hug and beg her to explain why she was so afraid. Catra had phrased that as gently as she possibly could, but this was a conversation that need to be had. Glimmer would never get through her backlog of work if this was just a fraction of what was waiting for her. Bright Moon was far behind even Perfuma's kingdom when it came to modernizing, And no offense to Perfuma, but she and her court spent more time sniffing plants

and singing around bonfires than doing actual kingdom work. Catra had seen it in person.

"Well, digitizing our records and documents *is* something we'd like to do," Elmira said. "Her Majesty has asked us to look into it, and there's considerable interest among the staff in doing so, after seeing what Entrapta has done for the others. But we just don't know where to start. There's so much that has to be done that even when we spend a half hour we don't have trying to plan what our first step is, we make no progress and end up hours behind on everything else that needs to be done."

Elmira sighed, crossing her arms and tapping her foot. She looked to be more agitated with herself than at any awkward position or spotlight Catra had placed her in.

"King Emeritus Micah helps as much as he can," she said, "but Glimmer being gone for such long periods of time makes it difficult to build momentum. Me specifically, I can't get started on any changes because I can barely keep up with the work pouring in as is. I didn't even know how to use the single computer they gave me because I was so tied up just keeping everything running. The study isn't even the records office, it's the overflow space."

"Wait," Catra said, narrowing her eyes. "There's another place that holds more documents?"

Elmira nodded. "The actual records room, yes."

Catra thought on that. If this was the state of the overflow, what did the true records room look like? Judging by the vaguely haunted look in Elmira's eyes, Catra had a feeling she didn't want to know.

"Elmira," she said instead, waiting for her to look her in the eyes. "You're the queen's Records Master, but I've literally not seen one person come in or out while I've been here. No one seemed to

even be in this wing of the castle. Are you the *only* person running this, I don't know, department? Or whatever it's called?"

Elmira swallowed and looked away again. Catra had all the answer she needed.

"Are you *kidding me*?" she asked. "You've handled all this by yourself when Glimmer isn't here? And you don't even have an assistant?"

Elmira's voice was painfully quiet when she responded, almost as if she thought she had been caught red-handed doing something wrong. "Well, the queen's father does help when he makes it in, like I said. And…yeah, I manage somehow, all the other times."

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. "Okay, next question," she said. "Have you asked for an assistant? Does Glimmer even know what your workload looks like?"

Elmira worried at her bottom lip and shook her head. Catra groaned and a blush tinged Elmira's cheeks when she did.

"Alright, first order of business then," Catra said, standing and pushing her arms high into a stretch, popping the bones in her back before sitting back down and gesturing to the stack on the desk. "These transit documents are not to be processed at any higher of a level than the officials stationed at the gates."

Elmira looked horrified, and Catra pressed on before she could voice any concern.

"The gate guards are trained enough to know if something is fishy or not, right? They don't have to send paperwork for literally every person who enters the kingdom, only if something doesn't check out with them. From now on, the only time you or the queen, or in this case the queen's proxy, has to deal with paperwork like this is if some suspicious character that creeps the guards out tries to get in. Is that clear?"

Elmira seemed on the verge of a panic attack fueled by unrepentant skepticism at that suggestion.

"How much time does that save us now that I don't have to look at this stack?"

"Maybe an hour and a half or two hours?"

"Great. We would have gone way over, because I only have half an hour left on the calendar. Neither of us are working into lunch either, by demand of the queen's proxy."

Catra put both hands palm flat against the table and leaned forward. "Here's what we're going to do with that time instead. We're going to go over everything you normally do to keep the records office running—all the paperwork that needs to be looked at and filed and stamped and whatnot, on top of everything I've already done. Then I'm going to decide what's really important and still needs doing, and what can be pushed off, at least until things are digitized and can go faster. Then we're going to draft something for Glimmer to look at when she feels better informing her of your working conditions. We're going to ask for at least *two* assistants. Maybe three. As soon as possible."

Elmira averted her eyes and made a fist, biting her knuckles.

"How does that sound?" Catra asked when Elmira still didn't say anything after a moment.

"That…sounds really nice, actually," Elmira said at last, visibly relaxing. She met Catra's eyes all on her own this time and actually looked excited for once, a small smile on her face. It faded as soon as Catra's own wicked grin appeared.

"Good. You're going to need them because, as proxy to the queen, I'm putting you personally in charge of Bright Moon's digitization project."

"What?"

"Yep, I'm making it your number one priority over everything else. All our records need to be digitized and be able to be electronically signed for within six months. You're going to be spearheading that."

Elmira's jaw dropped and she blanched. It wasn't until she and Catra went through all the work and categorized it into 'urgent' and 'non-urgent' buckets that Bright Moon's digitization effort seemed a much more manageable task, and Elmira calmed enough that normal color returned to her face.

"Wait, she's seriously been handling that all on her own? This whole time?" Glimmer looked damn near close to tears. All Catra could wonder was why she was upsetting everyone today.

"Yeah, you mean you didn't notice how cluttered the study was when you went?"

Glimmer shook her head. "Elmira always brought everything to my room and we'd gossip over snacks and drinks while we worked. I'd never set foot in there or in the records room since my mom was in charge."

Glimmer looked even worse than how Catra had left her in the morning, and that was before she brought her news about the working conditions of her Records Master. They were eating lunch together, Catra with a small plate of pasta and Glimmer with a massive bowl of bland soup the head nurse had insisted she have.

"You mentioned snacks," Catra said. "I wonder if I should have brought some. She seriously seemed terrified of me until I helped her organize everything she had to do. I took a lot off her plate because it was just stupid work. Not busy work, *stupid* work." She scowled at Glimmer. "Also, why do you get so much fan mail?"

That seemed to lift Glimmer's spirits, at least. "Is the fan mail part of the 'stupid, not busy' work you're talking about? Those are usually my favorite part."

"That part isn't stupid." Catra grumbled out the admission in spite of herself. "But everything else was. Did you seriously sign and stamp hundreds of pages of records about who enters and leaves the kingdom on a daily basis? Who the hell even writes all that stuff out for you to look at in the first place?"

Glimmer laughed and devolved into a coughing fit that racked her whole body. Catra steadied the bowl of soup in Glimmer's lap with one hand so it didn't spill, and leaned forward to pat Glimmer on the back to help her ride it through.

"Please don't die on me," she said. "That head nurse of yours is kind of scary, actually, and I really would rather not get on her bad side. Also, if you tell her I said that I'll deny everything. Can't let my image get tainted."

It was ironic because she actually was trying to change her image.

Glimmer's eyes bulged out of her head with incredulity. "Your *image?*" she asked. "What image?"

"You know, the one where I'm an unapologetic badass who's not afraid of anyone? That image."

Glimmer laughed again, and this time Catra joined her. They lapsed into silence as they went back to their food, only the sound of their utensils reverberating around the room.

"I can't believe she's just been carrying on by herself without saying anything," Glimmer said, breaking the silence. "She's too young to be doing all that, let alone be running a department by herself that normally takes at least three people."

"Who? Elmira?"

Glimmer nodded. "Her parents…they were the record keepers under my mom, both of them. They retired after Horde Prime's invasion, said they couldn't keep working with the night terrors and trauma from the invasion affecting them so badly. I was just

surprised Elmira wanted to take over. We used to play together when we were kids, you know."

Catra nodded but didn't say anything. She'd had never seen or heard of her before then, but her and Glimmer had so much history together. Elmira held an official title—Records Keeper for the Queen of Bright Moon—and Glimmer personally worried over her. Catra was welcome in the same circle now too since she was the royal advisor, but something about how she—prior enemy and leader in the Horde—was held with the same regard as someone with such a deep and historied tie to the kingdom made her feel unworthy of it.

Catra shook her head to clear the thoughts. She was part of something larger and far older than herself, now, and the realization struck an odd but pleasant note in her chest. Only then did she manage to move past that feeling of inadequacy.

"You know," Glimmer said, clearing her throat and growing strangely bitter. "Even though travelling and bringing magic back to the galaxy isn't exactly some kind of extended vacation, I still couldn't shake the feeling I was just leaving all my responsibilities here behind. Now it's even more obvious to me. Elmira and the others haven't been able to keep up with or even prioritize things without me around, even with my dad helping out where he can.

"I've known that paperwork block was pretty unnecessary and inefficient too, ever since I watched my mom go through her duties. I just never got around to instituting any changes after becoming queen, since we were so busy with…other things." Her expression turned somber, again. "I feel really bad I didn't address this sooner. Elmira probably hates me."

Catra snorted. "Fat chance of that ever happening. You should have seen the way she looked when she talked about all the letters you get and send to your subjects."

At Glimmer's look of confusion, Catra rolled her eyes and said, "Elmira isn't mad at you, she loves you. And she's going to

absolutely love you even more when you approve a budget increase to account for three assistants to help her out."

Glimmer nodded, enthusiastic enough it threated to slosh some of the soup out the bowl she cradled in her lap. "Anything. Whatever she needs. Are you sure just three will cut it?"

"Should be," Catra made a show of inspecting her nails to hide her sudden nerves. "She's going to focus on digitizing the records so there's less paperwork, and she'll need the extra bodies to take care of everything in the meantime while she focuses on that."

Realization dawned on Glimmer's face and she tilted her head back to sigh at the ceiling. "No wonder there has been almost no progress on the modernization efforts. If we don't even have digital records and she's too swamped to start converting them, everything is bottlenecked."

Catra blew out a breath; Glimmer liked the idea. "Yeah, that's why she needs the assistants," she said. "It should be done in six months. Or a sizeable portion of it should be done by then, at least."

"I'll make sure she gets staff before we have to leave again, at the very least."

Glimmer looked at Catra with a peculiar expression then, her head tilted to the side. Catra felt wary, and that feeling only intensified when a massive grin broke out across Glimmer's face.

"Look at you," she said, spooning another helping of soup for herself. "Only a few hours into the gig and you're making some sweeping changes. I like it."

Catra mumbled to herself, embarrassed and flustered as she twirled spaghetti around her fork.

A (big) part of her, on top of secretly loving that Glimmer made her an advisor because she believed in her skills rather than just because they were friends, also genuinely and desperately wanted

to make Glimmer proud. She wanted to prove beyond any doubt that she was cut out to *be* in Glimmer's inner circle in the first place, and she already knew she was going to ride the high from Glimmer's praise all the way through to the end of the week when Bow and Adora and everyone else returned.

Glimmer shot her a sly look and Catra swallowed, somehow knowing something devious was coming even though she didn't know what.

"I wonder how well all that brashness of yours will stack up against Sasha."

Catra knit her brows. Getting fitted for an outfit to hold court the next morning was all that was left on the agenda for the day. Glimmer had been right that, as soon as word got out a proxy had taken over for the week, one of his assistants had scheduled the entire afternoon and evening for it. Catra had wondered with no small amount of agitation why getting fitted for some clothes was going to take six hours, and Glimmer's comment just then only made her more nervous.

"I'm sure it will be fine," Catra said, putting on a cocky smile she sure as hell didn't feel confident in. "Remember that reputation of mine I mentioned like five seconds ago? Yeah, whoever this Sasha person is, I'm sure I can handle it."

Chapter End Notes

> This entire story sprung from a moment I imagined randomly one day, and it happens in this chapter: when Catra spends all day stamping meaningless paperwork, only for her to get near the end and snap when she realizes she's now about to stamp a form that's just approving yet another stamp to use xD Something about the absurdity of it all stuck with me.
>
> Thanks for reading! Any guesses on how well Catra's next meeting will play out?

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra could not handle Sasha. In fact, "handling" Sasha was about the furthest thing Catra could accomplish, in retrospect.

As soon as she pushed into the expansive royal fitting room, Sasha—or the "Queen's Wardrobe," as his official title read—almost immediately knocked Catra back onto her heels. Metaphorically speaking, of course.

"And so, the conqueror arrives," he said, peering at her over his tea shade sunglasses with a devil's smirk playing at his lips. The fact he wore sunglasses inside didn't even make him seem like an asshole, oddly enough. Catra gulped and refrained from making any smart quips as she padded further into the room.

"I won't put you in anything subtly hideous if you promise not to enslave me or my wardrobe staff," Sasha said, once she reached the raised dais and tri-fold body mirror everyone was standing around.

Catra gaped open-mouthed at him. She had noticed the side-eyed looks and caught bits and pieces of what was whispered about her when people thought she couldn't hear, but this was the first time someone had brought up her status as a former enemy right to her face. For someone whose entire career revolved around obsessing over how his clients looked, Sasha apparently held no qualms about saving face for himself; he'd throw Catra's dirty history out in the open on a whim.

Couple this with the fact Sasha had the power to instill a sense of legitimacy in her or make her look like a clown on the throne tomorrow by the clothing he had her wear, and Catra found she was truly fearful of him and felt no inclination to act cheeky or bratty as she might have with anyone else.

Catra wanted to say, "no promises," but what came out instead was, "no, absolutely not. I'm doing this to help Glimmer, so please don't make me look ridiculous holding court tomorrow."

Sasha regarded her for a long moment. His staff had stopped working too, and everyone in the room was watching them.

"Well, at least she can say 'please'," Sasha said, both eyebrows shooting up in mock (or was it genuine?) surprise. "Alright, Your Eminence. Let's get started."

Whereas Elmira made the honorific sound overly effusive, and thus annoying, Sasha somehow made it sound like an insult. Catra gulped and nodded again without a hint of protest. So much for her supposed badass reputation.

Sasha gestured to one of his staff and they hurried over, carrying a sheer bodysuit for Catra to change into. She took it and followed them to the back, where a set of changing rooms were partitioned off. Catra thanked the staffer, clicked the door shut behind her, and, finally alone, pressed her back against the door and exhaled a deep breath with her eyes closed. She had to concentrate to keep her knees from shaking. Why was this so stressful?

It came to her after a moment: Sasha reminded her of Double Trouble, except Double Trouble didn't have a long-standing sense of loyalty to the royal family that stretched back several generations through his own family line.

Glimmer had filled her in on who Sasha was. Just like Elmira, his own generational roots twined tight with Bright Moon's own history. Catra realized then that if she wanted to turn her image around—really turn it around in the minds of the kingdom's people—then being Glimmer's proxy and working alongside people like Elmira and Sasha was the perfect opportunity.

No, she *had* to turn peoples' opinions of her around. She was helping Glimmer because she was the royal advisor and her friend, yes, but she wanted to change peoples' opinion of her for

her own self. She wanted everyone to see her as an ally despite what happened in the past. And sure, Perfuma had talked her through all that sentiment about other peoples' opinions not mattering, and she had a point to some extent, but that didn't change Catra's goal in the slightest. There was a difference between wanting to be liked and wanting to not be hated.

Catra's nerves lessened somewhat then, after reaffirming what she was working toward and why. As for Sasha, she couldn't just keep from landing on his bad side. No, she had to prove herself to him somehow. Or at least not fuck up this fitting session. Maybe if she cooperated and they got her into an outfit that looked good, he'd be less outwardly antagonistic toward her?

Catra slid into the bodysuit and went back out. Sasha was inspecting a handful of fabric swatches at a table pushed against a support pillar with a careful eye. He paid her barely a passing glance when she returned.

"Up on the pedestal you go," he said, indicating the dais and the three full-body mirrors in the center of the room without turning away from what he was doing.

Catra stepped up and stood straight on the dais. The wardrobe staff of now twelve people surrounded her. Some were close enough they could reach out and touch, and others scrutinized her at a far enough distance it looked like they were appraising her as a part of her surroundings. All of them studied her as if she were a piece of art.

She caught a glimpse of herself in the mirror. The bodysuit technically covered more of her than what she had worn as Hordak's lieutenant—there was no cutout across her chest or accents cut into the legs. This new piece left only her head, feet, and hands exposed. And yet she'd never felt more naked in her life, standing there and being stared at by all these people. She felt as if she were modeling nude for an artist's figure drawing course, and the fact Sasha *still* didn't turn around and look at her while everyone else was only drove her nerves higher still.

Was she so unattractive or boring to look at that he just didn't care to?

That was silly, of course she wasn't boring or unattractive. She also didn't care if he looked at her either, to set the record straight. But still, *why* was he ignoring her? Catra shifted in place, trying to displace some of her pent-up anxiety.

"Don't fidget, dear, you'll just make it harder for my people to assess you."

Sasha had read Catra like a book without even looking at her, and before she had a chance to so much as *feel* completely seen through, he up four of the swatches he had been inspecting over his head, causing every head in the room to turn in tandem toward him.

"Start with these," he said. "Use it to improvise your own ideas."

Catra didn't realize he was talking to the staffers and not her until they reacted. Some of them broke off one by one, others in pairs, each heading off to fabric stations around the room where reams and cutouts of different fabrics hung on metal bars anchored to the walls. The few staffers who hadn't immediately gone for the fabric stayed put a while longer, appraising her. Catra guessed they were trying to solidify an image in their mind before getting to work, but they too eventually broke off toward the fabric like the rest.

Catra watched them work, entranced and no longer concerned over Sasha's lack of interest in her. The apprentice tailors and seamstresses had comradery, that much was obvious, and they clearly enjoyed their work. There was a sort of animated calm in the wardrobe room as groups of them spoke in excited, hushed tones with one another and compared or debated the various fabrics they had available. Catra caught some of them gesturing with their hands over the fabric as they glanced at her—it seemed they were also debating over what kind of cut and silhouette they wanted to give her and not just the colors or type of fabric.

Not long after and they started to come back to her on the dais, reams of fabrics forming tangled rainbow-gradient mountains in their arms. One by one they'd draw out individual pieces or paired fabric cuttings, sometimes three at a time, and hold them up against her sheer bodysuit. One by one, whether after a short glance or a longer, more purposeful scrutiny, they'd take it away with a shake of their head and a wrinkled nose.

One held up a ream of gorgeous blue satin next to another of deep, concentrated yellow. Both seamstresses next to them glanced between it and Catra, and then her reflection in the mirrors, and then back to Catra and their colleagues. Catra thought the colors complimented her eyes nicely and hoped they'd do something with it, but at last one of them shook their head, then the other did, and back to the rejected pile those colors went. Catra tried not to let her disappointment show.

She zoned out then, as even more fabrics came and went. Before long, she had spaced out so far that she lost track of how many colors the seamstresses and tailors tried with her, and she lost track of how long she had been standing there on the dais before the mirrors. A voice spoke, startling her out of the fog.

"Green and purple, Frances? Really?"

Every head in the room, including Catra's, spun toward Sasha. He stood leaning back into the table behind him, the one with the fabric swatches. His arms were crossed, and he was watching Catra and the activity around her with a hawk's gaze.

"I uh…well…" There was a woman holding up green and purple fabric to Catra's bodysuit. She looked perplexed, maybe a bit confused, but not afraid or panicked like Catra thought she might have been judging from Sasha's critical tone of voice.

"You also have stripes mixed with polka-dots in the design," Sasha said. "Might I remind you that her Eminence is *orange*? And not only is she orange, but she is also sufficiently lithe. You want to garb her in something that not only clashes with the color of her

fur but also draws specific attention to the fact she is as thin as a rail?”

The staff tittered under their breath and Catra flushed profusely. Sasha didn’t seem to be insulting her as much as merely voicing a subjective comment on her physique, so why was she so embarrassed?

What more, Frances, who he definitely *was* criticizing, took it in stride. She glanced back at the cuts of fabric in her hand and looked as if she had only just now noticed what she had picked out. Then, with a conciliatory smile on her face, she shrugged and said, “yeah, maybe not the best idea. Was just a thought.”

Catra didn’t get it. She had wanted Sasha to stop ignoring her while simultaneously telling herself she didn’t care where his attention was. And the moment he finally did pay attention to her, Catra immediately wished he hadn’t. This whole situation was going to give her emotional whiplash.

Sasha sighed and pinched the bridge of his nose. “Enough of this,” he said. “It is clear we are getting nowhere. Open up the far wall, please. Maybe then we’ll make some progress.”

By the way he spoke, Catra couldn’t shake the feeling he was more disappointed in her than in his staff. She couldn’t pinpoint exactly why, but she got the impression Sasha was waiting on her for something and she was failing to deliver.

She also had no idea what he meant when he told his people to ‘open up the wall.’

When Frances handed off her fabrics to someone else, she padded over to the wall beyond the dais and full body mirrors to press a button installed into the paneling. The wall itself slid further into the foundation, then pulled open, revealing a massive, fully stocked closet. Hundreds of items of clothing—mainly of different hues of purple but in all sorts of cuts—hung on two metal hangar bars stacked on top of one another and stretching

across the full expanse of the wall. Catra's jaw hinged open at the sight. Moth to the flame, she stepped off the dais and squeezed through the space between two of the mirrors, heading straight to the first item that caught her attention.

"These are amazing," Catra said. She ran gentle fingers across the fabric and stitching to feel at its texture.

"They're the queen's official ceremonial clothes," Sasha said, already at her side. Catra had no idea how he'd snuck up on her, and so quickly too. "Our best pieces are here, but I'm afraid many of Glimmer's and Angela's things wouldn't fit you." He wrinkled his nose. "Also, I don't think purple would match well with you."

Catra agreed with him. Purple was Glimmer's color and Catra thought it looked hideous on her own body, but even with that in mind she couldn't deny the clothes were exquisite. She'd always had an eye for style and quality, even growing up in the Horde when all she had to wear were ratty, fraying clothes. The longer she looked over the outfits, however, she noticed something.

"Pants," Catra said.

"Pardon?"

Catra glanced up and looked Sasha directly in the eyes. "Pants, shirts, jackets. No dresses. Everything in here is a dress of some kind."

Sasha quirked an eyebrow at her. "You don't want to wear a dress?"

Catra shook her head. It wasn't that she didn't like dresses, she just felt more comfortable in something similar to what she'd worn to Princess Prom. Adora was the only person she'd happily put a dress on for, if only to see the look of dumbstruck awe on her face. There was no way in hell she'd do it for whoever came to the royal court when she ran it the next morning.

“Every queen or queen’s proxy wears a dress. It’s tradition.” Sasha tilted his head. He didn’t look away, he didn’t blink, and his expression was stony and wholly unreadable. The man probably won fortunes in poker games.

Something clicked into place the next moment. This was what Sasha had been waiting on her for, Catra was sure of it. He wanted to gauge her reaction—see how she asserted herself, how she handled being challenged. He’d called her a conqueror when she first stepped foot in the room, and then ‘her Eminence’ when referring to her in front of his staff. Neither of those two names implied any sort of passivity. What had Catra done the past hour except stand there and let Sasha’s people hold fabric up to her body in front of a mirror?

“Yes,” she said, finding her courage and pouring it into her voice. “Bright Moon is weird. You guys barely use computers because all of your administration is old school and has been done on paper forever. But also, you’re progressive because you don’t even have a proper jail cell, and capital punishment is somehow something this kingdom has grown beyond.”

Catra didn’t break eye contact with Sasha. She didn’t even finish making her point, leaving it unspoken with the intent that she was now expecting *him* to intuit her point without her having to spell it out. She waited for his reaction and didn’t waver. Catra knew what she wanted: pants, at the very least.

“Don’t you mean to say that ‘we’ barely use computers, and that ‘we’ are progressive because we don’t have jails?” Sasha asked. “You’re the queen’s proxy, last I checked, not an outsider.”

Catra narrowed her eyes at him. He had a point, but she was the proxy and he needed to address her point first.

“You and your staff obviously are constantly looking at ways to innovate on how the royal family dresses,” she said. “Are you really going to make the case to me that I can’t wear pants to court because it’s outside of ‘our’ tradition?” She made air quotes

to emphasize her choice of 'our.' "We're exploring space and making contact with thousands of new worlds. Which side of the coming culture shift are you trying to be on?"

Sasha cracked a wide, unrestrained grin and laughed outright. Catra knew in that moment she had won him over. Probably. She'd broken his stony expression, at the very least. That was good, right? Progress?

"You've made your point," he said, before gesturing to his staff again. They moved to expose the wall on the opposite side of the room, revealing another wardrobe. Catra got an eyeful of what she assumed were Micah's clothes, neatly pressed and hung just like the dresses.

"None of these will fit you in particular," Sasha said, once they reached the other side of the room. "But see if you can find a design or color scheme you like. The plan was always to make a handful of outfits for you from scratch, rather than adopt something already made. You'll need at least *one* presentable thing for court tomorrow morning, and then something a little nicer for the dinner party."

Like Glimmer's clothes of the room, most everything in Micah's closet was made with various shades of purple, but Catra did find some darker and more aggressive palettes in there she liked. She pulled out a few outfits whose color caught her eye, then fished around for more in certain cuts and styles that she thought were interesting.

"How about some of these"—she held up two neon purple and pink pieces with interesting cuts before holding up those with colors she liked—"but in these shades?"

Sasha hmm'd and quirked an eyebrow, eyes darting between the two outfits and her. His staff were gathered around doing the same thing, obviously eager to see how "the Royal Wardrobe" interpreted Catra's own suggestion. As for Catra herself, her heart was beating so fast in her chest she thought it might stop.

“Some of these would do for one of your court appearances, but they’re not enough for the dinner,” he said. “The idea is to impress, not just mingle.”

Sasha turned to face the wardrobe and flipped through some other garments himself before coming away with another purple suit-adjacent outfit with an alluring silhouette. He held it up for Catra to inspect, voicing a clear question with nothing but a look he fixed her with. Catra already knew she liked it.

“Put it in red with black accents?” Catra asked. “Wait.” She reached forward toward the crew cut neckline and traced her claw down into a plunging ‘V’ that reached down almost to the navel. “What about something like this with the neckline?”

Sasha’s questioning gaze morphed into a look of impish glee. “Let’s take your measurements and I’ll see what I can do.”

By dinnertime, Catra felt she had enough of fitting for outfits to last a lifetime. It turned out, on top of taking nearly every measurement possible—and some measurements of places not even Catra realized existed on her body to measure in the first place—Sasha and his team had wanted to put together three fully-fitted mockups before letting her go. Them monopolizing the entire afternoon and pre-dinner evening block made sense the moment they told her.

Catra was so exhausted she almost fell asleep at the dinner table. Glimmer hadn’t shown, not that Catra had expected her to, and when she went to check in on her the head nurse shook her head and barred her from entry.

“The queen is asleep, I’m afraid,” she said. “She will have no visitors until she wakes in the morning. She needs her rest.”

Catra didn’t even have the energy to be disappointed. Riding the high she got from finally earning Sasha’s tentative respect had only lasted so long. She trudged back to her room, somehow

without falling asleep in the hallways. And from there, she barely stayed on her feet long enough to peel her clothes off the moment she locked the bedroom door behind her. The idea of taking a bath or shower crossed her before she decided that was a problem for "next morning Catra." She had a full morning of supervising court and then an apparently super-important dinner to host in the evening. If she didn't get to sleep now, she'd be dead on her feet the next day.

Catra fell into bed, took two seconds to mourn the fact she couldn't curl into Adora because she was still off in space doing gods-know-what, and promptly fell asleep.

Chapter End Notes

I searched way longer than I probably should have for the actual descriptor for 'Salt Bae Sunglasses' lol and the best I could find were 'tea shades.' Add to this the fact that Sasha, 1. wears them indoors, 2. this somehow makes him seem intimidating rather than an asshole, and 3. is comparable in mannerisms to Double Trouble (if Double Trouble were as loyal to and had as much history with Glimmer's family as Alfred was loyal to and had history with Bruce Wayne's family) and you can probably see why Catra might have wrestled a bit with this one.

Also, a Double Trouble-adjacent character with tea shades and an Alfred-level relationship to the royal family was something I somehow concocted in a fever dream and subsequently *had* to manifest in writing lol

Finding creative non-fighting ways for Catra to duel a person like this on their own turf, come out with a win, and also progress a new relationship was an interesting challenge :)

Also: Of course I know that Glimmer and Angella both wear pants throughout the whole show. Glimmer even has pants/leggings on in her coronation if I remember correctly. My somewhat explanation of this and Sasha being a stickler

about the dresses is either 1. the dresses are ceremonial only and Glimmer chose not to go full ceremonial during her coronation because of the escalating conflict with the horde, or 2. there is no actual tradition around dresses and Sasha was just being a dick to see how Catra would react to him pushing back on her :)

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Ok, if anyone reading this happens to have a formal educational or professional background in business law or tax law, please be prepared to up your suspension of disbelief xD You'll see that I indulged a bit in this chapter with the nuances in the conflict, and while I've done my best to think it through critically and make it make sense, I'm not an expert on either of these things and it may or may not show.
>
> On the other hand, if you *do* have experience in these areas and feel I did a good job, or if you feel like I did a good job in general, please tell me :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had fallen asleep the moment her head had hit the pillow the previous night. She reasoned that she could push everything off until the morning, including a bath, and that a good night's sleep would help prepare her for holding court in the morning.

Not to mention Sasha and his team had only gotten the initial frameworks and cuts for her outfits done the prior evening with the intention of working through the night to finalize everything; she still needed to get a final fitting before stepping foot into the throne room, and although their first meeting had started off rocky, Catra had gone to bed thinking common ground between her and Sasha wasn't as hard to reach as she might have initially thought.

Well, "next morning Catra" had decided almost immediately that Sasha was the worst.

He had woken her at the ass-crack of dawn, completely immune to any tactic she'd used to try and buy even a few more minutes of sleep, and hadn't stopped badgering her until she'd dragged

herself out of bed and into the bath the attendants had already prepare for her.

"We need to do another fitting and have enough time for final adjustments," was all the explanation he'd given for why she had to be conscious before the sun was even fully out yet.

Catra had decided, as she fought to keep from dozing off and drowning in her own bath water, that he was the devil-incarnate, a hell-spawn creature sent to torture her. He might have even competed with Horde Prime to take the top spot on her shit list. Or perhaps even Shadow Weaver. Maybe Shadow Weaver had sent him from the depths of hell to make her life miserable.

When she finished bathing, she realized she'd forgotten to grab a change of clothes in her sleep-deprived state. But before she could call someone to help, she saw another sheer bodysuit draped next to her towel hanging on the far wall: Sasha had already anticipated her. Maybe he wasn't so bad after all.

"These will be fine for court today and tomorrow," Sasha said the moment she stepped out of the bathroom. He was gesturing to two of the three outfits hanging on a wheeled clothing hangar.

She tried on both. The first had a pair of loose-fitting pants that exposed her angles, a blouse, jacket, and a stylish belt that complimented the rest of the ensemble and especially accentuated her waist and hips. Then she tried on the second: something a little tighter with a capelet. The whole thing reminded her of the uniforms the Bright Moon guards wore, if not quite as brightly colored and heavily armored.

Through the fog in her mind—now just clearing into semi-wakefulness—she remembered asking for red and black. Both pieces she'd tried on were blue and yellow, complimenting her eyes. In fact, she remembered seeing these exact hues and shades the previous night. Remembered trying to stifle her disappointment when Sasha's apprentices seemed to decide against using them.

Okay, she decided to walk back her assessment of him in the bath. Privately, at least. There was a third piece hanging next to the other two, but covered by a garment bag. Catra stared at it.

"This one is a bit more delicate," Sasha said after following her gaze. "I need to sew it on you directly and chalk the final measurements from there."

"It's that rough?" Catra asked, surprised. How did they get two full outfits pretty much spot on for her court appearances, but still have to sew on the dinner outfit?

Sasha smiled something devious at her. "Like I said last night, the aim is to impress, not just mingle. This one will fit you perfectly, even more so than the others." He pulled out a sleep blindfold from his pants pocket and held it out to her. "I'd prefer to keep it a secret even from you until tonight. I'll still ask you to close your eyes anyways if you're not comfortable with the blindfold, but this will remove the temptation to peek."

Catra glanced at the blindfold with raised eyebrows and marveled at the fact she didn't feel uncomfortable at all about the proposition. Her first instinct might have been to imply something crass, but she could only fixate on how Sasha was making her something so special it outclassed the other two already superb outfits she'd tried. The fact he implied he was going to work on it personally wasn't lost on her either. Catra didn't think someone who still held a grudge would willingly go to such lengths for her.

She took the blindfold and didn't even attempt to hide her own smile when she slotted it over her eyes.

Even if she couldn't see what he'd planned for her just yet, she knew it'd be good. The outfit and fact she'd very shortly get to sit on the throne and officially hold court in Glimmer's stead had her jittering in anticipation. The sun was just starting to peek through the bedroom windows, and she was already having a blast.

Ten minutes was all it took for Catra to hate sitting on the throne.

Sasha had done a magnificent job with her first court-appearance outfit considering that no matter how she sat or moved, the fabric adjusted with her and made her seem all the more authoritative because of it. But not even that could save her from the hell that was holding official court.

The really disappointing thing was that she had actually been looking forward to this—sitting on the throne, holding court, being a figurehead, even temporarily, for the very subjects that loved Glimmer oh so much. This was the first time she'd been put in charge of anything after leading the Horde as second in command, and representing Glimmer as her proxy to the kingdom was infinitely more preferrable in her mind than having held a leadership position previously purely out of spite and hatred. She thought it'd be invigorating to do this, at least.

The seat itself was uncomfortable and it dug into her in places no matter how she sat. Courtly procedure was terribly dull with how every visitor to the throne had to be explicitly announced and how she was referred to as 'Your Eminence' several times a minute now instead of only on the occasional off-hand moment in the preceding days. Also, *everyone* spoke and acted as if they had a supremely uncomfortable stick up their ass.

Catra had vastly overestimated how cool it was to be in charge. Twice, now.

Finally, it was near the end of the morning court session, just before lunch. Two brothers were standing before her, the last audience she was to grant, and she'd zoned out of their entire preamble. It wasn't until one of them stated outright what they wished her to do that she realized this situation might be something interesting after all.

"—and we just need Her Majesty Glimmer, or, in this case, Your Eminence, to clarify once and for all what the official language of the document is meant to convey." One of the brothers—the older

one, if she remembered correctly from when they'd been introduced two minutes ago—pressed his hands together in a solemn gesture.

Catra perked up. All the other audiences she'd granted had dealt with mundane topics: approving patronage for various artistic endeavors, for example, or signing off on additions or modifications to coats of arms for various minor clients and vassals under the royal family. She'd even had to give the "royal court's official opinion" on whether or not taste testing the meat and fruit of magically-reappeared flora and fauna on Etheria was considered a "voluntary risk" that current health and life insurance policies were expected to cover or not.

But this? The brothers' request implied something deeper—her explicit interpretation of a legal document, it seemed. There was a system of lower and higher courts in the land, Catra knew that much. The fact they were bringing this to the royal seat, though, meant only one thing.

"Let me see the current law, as it's written," she said.

The court scribe was a woman who couldn't be much older than herself, but she was the only one Catra had seen using any of the new technology Entrapta had made for them with any sort of familiarity. She typed Catra's request into her stenograph and whispered to one of the attendants seated next to her. They rifled through some papers, collected a modest stack together, then hurried over to the throne to pass them off to Catra with a hurried bow.

Catra scanned through the papers, amazed at how well-organized and succinct everything was. She'd expected to wade through endless paragraphs of dense legalese, but everything relevant had already been collated into a few, easily readable pages. Even the rulings of the previous courts as well as the brothers' litigious history from the lower circuits to the higher ones were summarized for her. Catra glanced toward the scribe, impressed, and the scribe smiled back with a knowing look.

Maybe I should see if she can help Elmira, Catra thought. No doubt they'd be a strong asset for digitizing all the records if she were this organized already. Unfortunately for the brothers, the quick-notes version of their predicament made the issue in question jump out at her. They had inherited the family farming and shipping business from their parents, with the farming portion going solely to the elder brother and the distribution portion going to the younger. Both were mutually independent organizations tied together with a joint venture contract between them, and none of the rulings from the previous courts had settled their squabbling over the demarcation of their shared tax burden. It wasn't even about the taxes themselves, but a disagreement in how the law about the taxes was to be interpreted.

"Let me get this straight," she said, piercing both brothers with a steel gaze reminiscent of the scowl she'd taken to wearing under Hordak. "You escalated this beyond the lower and higher courts in the kingdom, appealing all the way to the royal seat so that the absolute monarch of the land would have to hear your case, because of a *typo*? In a law that outlines how business tax deductions are assigned?"

Both brothers faltered, casting uncertain glances at one another. "Pardon us, Your Eminence?" the older one said.

Catra crossed her legs and tapped her claws on the throne's arm rest as she considered her words. This reaction wasn't new to her after spending the whole morning holding court. Apparently, Angella, Micah, and Glimmer had all been exceedingly conciliatory with their subjects in the past, so dealing with someone like Catra —what with her prickliness and short temper—was something new for them.

"I mean, that *is* why you're here, right?" Catra asked, choosing to confirm her suspicions before reaming these two. "You're squabbling over tax deductions between your businesses because you feel the law is unclear. And instead of taking the rulings handed down by your local district court, the appellate court, and Bright Moon's High Court, you've decided to try and circumvent all

of that by escalating directly to the queen." She gestured directly to the elder brother—he'd been the one to escalate the suit to her at the end, not the younger one. "That's what you've chosen to do, right?"

The brothers, especially the older one, fidgeted again, mumbling under their breaths. Catra hadn't even bothered to learn their names despite the fact they had been announced earlier.

"Our family business is very important to me," the elder said, his eyes pleading with her in a comical show of deference. "I just want what's best for our family's legacy."

The younger brother snorted and crossed his arms. "If you wanted what was best then you would forward me the portion of our tax deductions I'm owed," he said. "The agricultural division you inherited makes more than enough revenue. You don't need the extra subsidy, and the shipping operations I've taken over are slipping because I defer any new contracts I *could* be taking on to help with logistics for your grain."

He turned away from his brother to address Catra directly. "Those deductions are vital to help me stay afloat. We file jointly through his operation's accounting function. I don't have my own and can't afford my own, but he will not allow me to claim deductions I'm rightly owed and instead says that I cannot claim them, and attempting to do so through his accountants will expose both of us to legal jeopardy. These are finances that I could use to reinvest in my logistics operations. Holding out on what rightly should be mine because of a lack of a comma is not 'doing what you think is best for the business.'" He made air quotes at that last part.

The elder rolled his eyes. "Yeah, and your business thriving or drowning really depends on a handful of tax deductions that are disputed in the first place. It's fundamentally mismanaged, and we need to do something about it. Not squabble over grammar."

"The backpay from those deductions, if they're interpreted the way the law is *supposed* to read, amount to almost a quarter of my operating overhead! It has nothing to do with mismanagement, you just have no idea how to run a shipping operation since all dad ever showed you was how to farm crops! It's not my fault you found distribution boring."

They devolved further into mindless bickering and Catra slapped both her hands down on the throne's arm rests hard enough for the sound to echo around the throne room sanctum.

"Enough!" she said, startling not just the brothers but the guards in the throne room with them. After several moments of stark silence ticked by, Catra sat back in the throne and held up the document with the law and the scribe's notes before her. She cleared her throat and began to read aloud.

"The processing, preserving, freezing, drying, marketing, storing, packing for shipment or distribution of"—she paused, as that was the circled part of the document highlighting the singular point of contention—"one: agricultural produce; two: meat and fish; three: other such perishables including but not limited to blah blah blah within the kingdom of Bright Moon shall be awarded tax deductions as follows: one fiftieth total revenue for yadda yadda, etcetera, etcetera…."

Catra rolled her eyes. This was what had piqued her interest after so many mindless audiences she had fielded earlier in the morning? She peeked up at the brothers over the top of the papers, questioning them with nothing but a look.

"The law was intended to provide deductions for packing and distributing separately" the younger said. "But my brother chooses to interpret the law as providing deductions only on packaging *for* distribution. His workers pack the produce, we load and distribute, and since his guys do the packaging for distributing, he gets to eat all of the subsidy benefits and I have to make do with none of it. This is despite the fact my operating overhead is far

more volatile than his, and the law is intended to also provide the deduction for the actual shipping itself."

"You don't know what the law intended to say," the elder brother said. "The courts interpret and apply the law, not you. Her Eminence just read off the law as written, you heard it yourself. You aren't entitled to any of the tax deductions. My workers do the packaging, my workers earn the deductions when we report to the tax office. You don't see any of the written-off portions of our joint revenue because your operations account for no part of what can be written off."

"You're right," the younger said. "I have no claim to be able to accurately interpret the law's intention. But do you know who does? All the judges we went and saw before coming to the royal throne."

"Yeah, and two of the three prior judges agreed with my assessment. Distribution is not included in the tax deductions. Just packing. Which, again, my guys do."

"Can the both of you just shut it for three seconds? My god, it's like I can barely even hear myself think in my own head, your bickering is so relentless." Catra narrowed her eyes at them and bared her fangs as she spoke. Both of them clammed up, and she used their silence to look over the final pages the scribe and her assistants had handed over: the judge opinions from the prior court appointments.

"Both of the judges that ruled in your favor," Catra said, indicating the older sibling, "did so not because they thought you were right, but because they didn't feel they had the authority to comment on the 'spirit' of the law, only what it actually said. They didn't want to set a precedent where their interpretation of the conflicted with its actual application in practice. It's written clearly here in their opinions.

"It was the highest court, the one you went to before me, that ruled differently. According to them"—she cleared her throat and

affected a courtly voice as she read—"the spirit of the law would indicate that because the shipping operations do materially contribute to the profitability of the joint venture as a whole, it should therefore receive a commensurate portion of the benefit earned from its lowered taxable income through Bright Moon Kingdom's subsidized tax deductions."

She looked back up at the brothers again and spoke to them directly. "The High Court says there's a typo."

The older brother had grown more unsteady the longer Catra spoke, and by the end of it he seemed to be seriously regretting his decision to escalate all the way to the throne. Catra herself, on the other hand, was surprised at herself.

Despite how mundane all this was, she'd grasped the subject matter rather quickly and felt comfortable enough with it to put confidence behind her words without having to force it. Maybe it was the chair, maybe it was Sasha's outfit, or maybe it was actually her, but she finally felt like she had authority to apply somewhere it was needed: in a domestic tax dispute of all situations. She wasn't going to kid herself, though. The scribe's collations did a lot of the heavy lifting already, and were largely to credit for her being able to dive straight to the problem.

"Nothing to say?" Catra asked, prompting the elder as a tentative smile formed on the face of the younger. "You were adamant this be escalated here after the High Court's ruling. Do you dispute their findings that the law was written with a typo?"

The older brother made some non-comital comments about the two decisions prior to the High Court still agreeing with him, and how he thought the letter of the law that was passed was more important than how the law was then interpreted. Catra paid no attention to any of it, taking his lack of passion on the subject and his sudden timidity as proof enough that he was full of shit.

"It's settled then," Catra said. She gestured with a grabby-hands motion to the scribe's assistant and they brought her a pen and

the royal seal she had used the previous day to stamp documents. "The ruling from the High Court shall stand, and I'm fixing the typo." She uncapped the pen, drew a careful comma so the law now read "*packing for shipment, or distribution of*" then stamped the paper, before handing it back.

The assistant looked bewildered, as did both brothers. The scribe herself was trying so hard to keep from descending into laughing fits that her face had turned red. Catra willed her tail not to thrash out of amusement in the seat; she knew what she just did likely broke all sorts of bureaucratic red tape. There was a process for changing laws, even for a queen or her proxy, and merely correcting a copy of a heavily edited document and stamping it with a seal technically wasn't how any of it was to be done.

The younger brother cleared his throat. "Does this mean I'm also awarded the payout commensurate with previous deductions retroactively, as requested?"

"Oh yeah, thanks for reminding me about that," Catra said. She had almost forgotten, fixated instead on how everyone in the throne room reacted to her flagrant disregard for procedure. "No. The law will be changed so you receive tax deductions starting this tax period, but you won't be awarded any lump sum payments had the law been applied retroactively."

The younger brother wilted. "But, Your Excellency, my business…it really is struggling. If I don't get some sort of infusion, even in the short term, then it's likely that—"

Catra held up her hand to head him off. "I wasn't done," she said.

She'd paid attention to the information the scribe had included about the nature of their business, as well as her writeup on the current health of each brother's respective portions of the joint venture. She knew exactly how close to failing the shipping portion was, but she couldn't just side so heavily with one party over the other in a dispute like this, especially as just a stand in for the queen. It really would set a bad precedent for Glimmer

when she took over her duties again if Catra had unilaterally made decisions like that. She had to carry forward some semblance of impartiality, and that would take a bit of creativity on her part in this situation.

"The deductions will be granted on top of the deductions your brother's farming operations already received. You will not claim deductions he had previously, you will claim your own. But, seeing as the deductions are applied across both your businesses as a single entity rather than separate, you will need to receive a larger proportion of the benefit of those deductions for the foreseeable future. This will continue until the amount you would have saved over the duration of your time in business with your brother is earned back."

To Catra's pleasant surprise, both brothers seemed equally unenthused about the idea. This would work, and she took the fact neither was particularly happy about her plan as a sign of a good compromise.

"Your Excellency," the older brother said. "I'm not sure if that's—"

"Under the amended law, what percentage of the total tax deductions does the shipping company get awarded?" Catra had turned to the scribe and her attendants, among which was a team of analysts that made themselves available during the queen's court appearances specifically for questions like these. "Run an estimate off their last three years of filings."

"Six percent, Your Excellency," one of them said after a moment of frantic scribbling and calculating on paper. "Up from the zero percent internal split from the joint venture's books, historically. Even with the deduction now being acknowledged on the shipping side, it still a minor portion of the overall deduction amount."

Catra nodded, before turning back to the older brother. "How important is your family's agriculture business to you?"

The older brother seemed almost offended to be asked that in the first place. "Very much, Your Excellency. Our parents entrusted it to the both of us before they passed away. I can't speak for my younger brother, but I personally would not know what to do with myself if it went under. And that's not just speaking for the agricultural side, but the shipping side as well, believe it or not."

That was exactly what Catra was hoping to hear, and she smiled, earning an uncertain look back.

"Good. I know ordering your business to backdate and repay your brother's side of things would threaten your own operations, so I won't order that. In the meantime, until that backdated sum is paid back in full, however, he will receive the benefits of sixty-five percent of the entire joint venture's tax deductions, not just the portion that has to do with distribution. Whatever Royal Taxes you pay every period, the lion's share will come out of revenues you claim.

"Whatever tax return you both receive at the end of the filing year, he will receive an outsized portion when you divide it. Both of these will happen so he can reinvest and build stability back into his side of things, and this is a special exception for your family's business only. Once the sum is earned back, deduction apportionments will return to what the new letter of the law dictates. Six percent, and ninety-four." She glanced at the scribe to cue her in and said, "I'll need both of you to sign a new agreement to this effect with the royal family as arbitrator and witness before you can go."

The older brother swallowed and looked away. It was clear he was unhappy with the decision but wouldn't challenge her on it. To her surprise, however, the younger brother still looked unimpressed.

"Your Excellency," he said. "While I understand and appreciate what you are trying to do, I must admit I am uncomfortable with it. We are a joint venture with separate official management structures, and our contract between each other stipulates that he and I are free to do business independently of one another. He

does not need my distribution resources to continue doing business. He can likely find hundreds of other distributors, but since he has capitalized on my willingness to distribute for only him out of my love for our family's heritage, I have no other partners I can distribute for on short notice if he decides to pit me against competition for contracts. After having known him for as long as I have, I am not convinced he may fundamentally alter our working relationship after this goes into effect and essentially hold me hostage."

That got a reaction out of the older brother. After all, they were serious accusations, and he looked on the verge of exploding in rage. But Catra was in no mood to hear yet another outburst; it was almost time for lunch, and she was starving.

"I'm sure we could sit here all day and go around in circles, debating how we all feel about changes that are bound to be controversial no matter how they're put in," Catra said, raising her voice at first to head off the older brother before he started to rant. "But at some point, a decision has to be made. To be fair, I did consider that happening as well."

Everyone in the throne room looked to her with rapt interest. What kind of plan did she have?

"If either of you—not just one of you, but *either* of you—choose to try and fuck over the other, the kingdom will know. You might not be one of the larger producers, but you'd both still fall under what's considered 'key infrastructure' for the kingdom, producing food and supplying it. If the business fails—either part of it, for whatever reason—rest assured that the royal family will step in and take matters into their own hands. I mentioned you both signing an agreement because it's still your joint venture. Regardless of how either of you *actually* feel about the family business, I'm fairly certain neither of you want it inadvertently turned into a state-run enterprise instead. Am I wrong?"

Neither brother looked her in the eye, and they shuffled their feet underneath them as if they were children caught doing something

they weren't supposed to.

"Good," Catra said. "It's decided then." She gestured to the scribe and asked her for a printed transcript of the last minute or so of her words only. After a moment, she had a document in her hand that had her decree assigning an outsized portion of the tax deductions to the younger brother until he was made whole. She signed the document in a large, sweeping font with her pen, then stamped it with the seal, handing it back to the attendant.

"Make it so," she said, giving a cheeky 'go on now,' gesture with her hands. The scribe finally lost her composure outright and burst out, her peals of laughter echoing down the hallway. Catra smirked. What would Glimmer have to say about this?

"You threatened to take over their business?!" Glimmer nearly spat out her portion of soup when Catra caught here up to speed during lunch. "We aren't despots, Catra. I'd never force someone to hand over a family endeavor unless it was a true emergency."

"I mean, it worked, didn't it?" Catra shrugged. She knew the scowl on Glimmer's face was only half-hearted. Besides, she was still too sick and looked more like a half-drowned cat frowning in misery than intimidating. "Technically I just implied that we *might* take over if they fail. The actual words I used were that we'd 'step in', and it might 'inadvertently' become state-run." She fixed Glimmer with a placid look and said, "it's in the transcript I signed and stamped. I can show you."

Glimmer did want to see, and before long even she admitted Catra's method of getting things done, while unorthodox and somewhat scary, was highly effective.

"There really was a typo in that law," she'd said, after looking over the wording and the change Catra had made to it. "I'm glad you fixed it. It's just…you've seen how stressed my staff gets trying to do something as simple as digitize our records. Can you imagine how freaked out they're going to be when they find out *how* you

amended the law? They’re all going to blow gaskets trying to figure out how to incorporate stamped court transcriptions into our actual codified statutes.”

“I know,” Catra said, grinning between bites of her own food. “I trust they’ll figure it out. That scribe of yours seems pretty capable.”

“You’re nuts.” Glimmer chuckled and shook her head. “I’m not sure you’ll be able to get away with approaching any problems the same way if they crop up at the dinner tonight, though. If you thought Sasha was a handful, just wait for Marianna”

Catra swallowed and nodded. Glimmer had been fixated on the dinner she was hosting since the previous morning, and Sasha had alluded to its importance by way of wanting to make an outfit for her that ‘impressed, rather than mingled.’

“I’m sure it will be fine,” she said, before immediately regretting it. If there was one thing she’d learned, it was to never say that out loud.

Chapter End Notes

Inspiration for this particular vignette came from two places:

First, if you read the third book in John Scalzi's Old Man's War, called "The Last Colony," it opens up with two brothers bothering the main character about something supremely stupid (rearing rights for a goat owned by one brother that impregnated the goat of the other brother, if I remember correctly). Catra's solution to the problem in this chapter and the whole premise between two arguing siblings was based off this.

Second, the typo in the law itself was inspired by an actual issue caused by omitting an oxford comma. If you're curious, look up 'Oakhurst Dairy Lawsuit' in your favorite search engine. I want to say I lifted the actual legal language near-verbatim when Catra read it aloud.

I merged these two things as best I could for a She Ra fanfic scene and the jury is still out if I succeeded in making it entertaining and coherent lmao, please let me know your thoughts.

Next up is the fancy dinner, which I think is my favorite chapter in the whole story. People have looked down on Catra for her past, and Catra puts *herself* down for it at times too. I got to play around with making that whole 'Ex-Horde, Once-Conqueror' aspect of her history into something positive and affirming, and it was super fun.

See you soon!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The dinner was shaping up to be something truly interesting, judging by the frenetic, anticipatory energy thrumming throughout the castle staff going about their preparations. Despite how boring holding court in the morning had gone—even with that nonsense about the two brothers—Catra wasn't looking forward to it. Fortunately, trying on the outfit Sasha had prepared for her helped mutate some of her anxiety into real excitement.

"You are a genius," she said to him as she looked herself over in the full body mirror set up in her and Adora's shared bedroom. "Seriously, I don't think I've ever worn anything like this in my life."

Sasha laughed through his nose. "Yes, well I suppose you've never had anything made bespoke by a master tailor before."

Catra hummed her agreement and posed again, studying how the outfit draped over her as she moved. Sasha had made a red satin jump suit with accents that drew attention to her best features. And, just like she had suggested when first picking out designs in the wardrobe room, there was a near-scandalous plunge in the neckline. One that Sasha had taken damn near all the way to her belly button. With every move of her body, it seemed to threaten anybody around with a full view of things they probably should not have seen.

But that was the thing: all it did was "threaten." Catra could tell just from the way it hugged her that she was in no danger of flashing anyone on accident. How Sasha got it to feel so secure she had no idea, although she suspected that's why he had to the rough cut onto her and do a final measurement that morning. And damn did it work—she felt like she could conquer all of Bright

Moon a second time with what she had on, and with far less artillery to boot.

"Like I said," Sasha said, winking at her when she met his eyes in the mirror. "Dress to impress, not just mingle. It will help with tonight."

She frowned at that. Judging from the way Glimmer described her guests for dinner, Catra was in for a long, challenging night.

"Hey," she said to Sasha, partially as a way to deflect the anxiety mounting again. "We're supposed to be having Princess Prom at Bright Moon this year, in like a month or two. Any chance I can get something like this from you but in actual dress form?"

Sasha seemed surprised, although that surprise turned quick to laughter. "It will be hard to outdo myself after this, but I think I'm up for the challenge."

It was the first time Catra didn't feel strangely intimidated in his presence. More and more she came to believe she'd won him over, despite how tense their first interaction had been.

Adora was going to lose her shit when she saw Catra in whatever dress he'd make for her. She almost couldn't wait for Princess Prom to come, which was odd because she'd complained endlessly about it to everyone aboard Darla during the preceding adventures the minute Glimmer had announced it.

"Are you sure you don't want the thing?" Sasha asked, interrupting her musings by gesturing to his own forehead to indicate the 'thing' he was talking about.

Catra considered it. "Nah," she said after a moment. "I think this is good enough to start. You said the idea was to impress, not cause a heart attack."

Sasha pouted. "That's fair, I suppose."

The guests had already arrived and were waiting for her in the castle foyer when she left the bedroom. Catra had worried in the back of her mind that things might not go well—she'd always had a pessimistic streak. But the fact they'd arrived earlier than anyone could predict meant she hadn't been there to greet them personally like Glimmer had suggested. Catra was convinced the night was already well and truly fucked before it began.

"Countess Marianna," she said, putting on her biggest smile and extending a hand for the towering woman in front of her to shake. "I was under the impression we weren't to expect you for another half hour at least. How was your journey?"

The countess, dressed in a flowing blue dress and wearing an opal necklace, stared down the length of her nose at Catra's extended hand. Her eyes flicked from her hand to her body, tracking down and then back up the length of her outfit, the disdain on her face growing deeper with each passing second. Catra didn't waver despite how her heart thumped in her chest, and it was the countess who broke their stalemate in the end.

"Long and bumpy," she said, taking Catra's hand in a limp handshake. "My county is focused on animal husbandry. We don't have the luxury of buying those fancy new spaceships the larger kingdoms are all seeming to splurge on."

Catra nodded took her hand back when the countess released her, unsure of what to do with it now that it was free. This was going to be such an uphill battle. The attendants in the dining room and cooks in the kitchen were scrambling to put the finishing touches on everything since they still weren't done.

Grasping for any opportunity at all to stall, Catra leaned to the side and looked past the countess at her retinue: an infant girl bouncing in the arms of a harried looking nanny, and a gangly looking teenager with peach fuzz on his face. He shuffled his feet and cast quick glances at Catra. When he realized she'd caught him sneaking glances at her, he looked away and his face turned red and splotchy.

Catra herself tried to keep from going the same shade as him, but she was embarrassed for a whole other reason. This was a *family* dinner, she'd realized with belated horror. It was just the countess, her children, and one nanny. The way Glimmer and everyone else had spoken about tonight, it sounded like a larger event with the countess' family as headliner, not an intimate affair between two noble houses. Why had Catra suggested wearing something that exposed almost her whole chest, and why the hell did Sasha agree it was a good idea and go through with making it? He might have encouraged her to go for something more tasteful, at least!

"Did Count Frederick forget something back in your ride?" Catra asked the countess, wincing at how colloquial 'ride' had sounded spoken aloud. Her throat had suddenly gone bone dry and it was hard to speak without a rasp. "I'm sure the queen's staff would be more than happy to fetch whatever it is he might have accidentally left behind in your carriage outside."

"My husband will not be joining us this evening, I'm afraid.

That didn't sound right. "Is everything okay? I was under the impression I would be hosting the both of you, along with your children tonight." She decided not to mention how she'd mistakenly believed she'd be hosting a lot more than just them. That particular slip up she'd take to the grave, or potentially dump wholesale, with emotion, on Adora's lap when she came back. Catra wasn't sure yet.

"And I was under the impression we would be dining with the queen, not some stand in." The countess gave a flippant gesture with her hand before folding her arms across her chest. "I was not informed of any last-minute changes. Where is Queen Glimmer and why has she decided I am apparently not important enough to spend time with only *after* I traveled for several hours to get here?"

Catra exhaled slow and methodically and kept her tail from puffing up in indignation. Dumping this whole slip up on Adora's lap seemed more and more likely. She might have even gotten mad if

it weren't for the fact the countess' words made one thing abundantly clear: she had no idea who Catra was. Sasha had announced his opinion of her the moment she step foot in the wardrobe room, calling her a conqueror, and Catra had a sneaking suspicion Elmira was so afraid of her at first because she too knew who Catra was.

The countess being completely unaware of her identity, however, was an interesting situation to find herself in.

"The queen has taken ill," Catra said, slipping a smile back on her face as if it were the most natural thing for her to do. "She's currently holed up in bed, guarded under lock and key by the royal nurse and her team. Her majesty would have better luck breathing in space without a helmet than convincing them to let her come to this dinner. That being said, she cared so much about hosting for you tonight that she asked me to entertain you in her stead." Catra pressed her palm to her chest and gave a shallow half-bow. "I am terribly sorry, but will you do the Kingdom of Bright Moon the honor of dining with the Queen's Proxy instead? I am Catra, close friend and confidante to the royal family, as well as their official senior advisor."

A tense silence fell between them as the countess appraised Catra through squinted eyes. Catra wondered if that introduction had jogged something in her memory. She was infamous more by her looks than her name—the people of Bright Moon hadn't known that it was "Catra, Force Captain of the Horde" that had nearly conquered them, but they recognized her when they saw her, ears and tail and heterochromia and all.

Marianna gave another sniff and a shrug. "Very well, Catra of Bright Moon. I'm still not happy the queen cannot be here, but I suppose a meeting with *someone* would be preferable to another cancellation. And at least you have manners and etiquette, which is more than I can say for most."

Catra refrained from snickering, since that was almost the same thing Sasha had said to her the other day, too. This all but

confirmed Marinna had no idea who she really was, even with the introduction.

One of the kitchen attendants rushed up to her and whispered in her ear that the dining room staff and chefs were ready for them. With another smile—one that she felt much better about wearing this time—Catra beckoned the countess and her family (and nurse) to follow her to the dining room.

"The production quotas Bright Moon has set for us are too high."

They'd only just finished the soup and salad appetizer courses, and Catra already felt dangerously close to ripping her hair out. Or maybe Marianna's. And Catra had worn her fake smile so long now she was afraid she'd be unable to unstick it and actually eat when the main course finally came out.

"Please," Catra said through gritted teeth, "tell me more. Your lands have always supplied plenty. This is the first time I've ever heard of issues, or quotas for that matter. I was under the impression we just place orders with your distributors and you fulfill them. There aren't supposed to be quotas." Glimmer had talked her ear off nonstop during their adventures about how things worked with Bright Moon and its surrounding client territories, so she knew this much, at least.

"Regardless, we just cannot keep up. Demand is high, and I'm afraid we'll lose our standing if we are not able to fulfill as much of the orders as we have in the past."

Marianna's infant daughter babbled nearby in her high chair as the nanny tried to feed her, The countess ignored both of them, and then ignored the staff as they brought out the main course on wheeled serving trays.

"We lose workers every week. More than we can hire on," she said. "Attrition is abysmal and there's a work shortage. We'd *like* to purchase upgraded equipment that makes our production more

efficient so we can make do with less headcount, but we don't have the capital for that, and our government credit isn't strong enough for a traditional loan that suits our needs." She tilted her head to the side, picked up her fork form the table and gestured at Catra with it. "How would you respond if my county were to send an official request for subsidy to Bright Moon?"

Catra perked up at that. This was the first time Marianna had engaged her or asked her anything since they sat. It still amazed her that the countess hadn't shut up once since they started eating , but maybe now she could finally get a word in? She opened her mouth to respond, only to get cut off a moment later.

"Oh, my Edward has his own opinions on why we struggle," Marianna said, turning to her teenage son. "Why don't you share your ideas with the Queen's Proxy, Eddy?"

Edward was already turning red again under his mother's scrutiny, and when Catra turned to him, he flushed an even deeper shade of it.

"Uhm," he said, voice quavering. "Well, yeah. I mean, the workers all talk about low wages and long hours. There are plenty of independent businesses that offer more incentive to work for them, and being employed by our family isn't as prestigious as you'd think. I think that's why we have so much trouble hiring more people to—"

"Isn't he just so adorable?" Marianna said. "He's got all these ideas about how to 'improve' the county. I'm sure he'll make a good ruler once he eventually takes the reigns from my husband and I, but he's still got a lot to learn, as you can tell." She gave the most condescending and patronizing laugh Catra had ever heard, even compared to Shadow Weaver, and shook her head. "'Not as prestigious', he says. Working for a noble family such as ours is not prestigious? Hah."

Edward slumped his shoulders forward, dejected, and Catra couldn't help the pang of sympathy she felt for him. Sure, the kid

had a massive hormonal teenage crush on her and she couldn't bring herself to feel even tangentially flattered about it, but it was *clear* what his mom's attitude was doing to him. She wondered if the countess even realized what effect she was having on her kid. Shadow Weaver *knew* what she was doing to Catra and Adora—it was a purposeful thing. But did the countess know too, or was she just ignorant? Catra couldn't decide which was preferable.

Catra looked to the nanny. She was still doing her best to feed both herself and the countess' infant daughter, who had food smeared all over their face, their bib, and even had some tangled in their hair. Catra wondered what the family dynamic would be like when she grew old enough to understand how they were forces out of her control that shaped her fundamentally. Edward definitely understood already, or at least acutely felt the effects.

Sasha had told her, casually during their fitting session earlier, about how it was rumored the count and countess had another child solely as a means to hopefully reinvigorate their failing marriage. And although Catra already knew she'd never think something like that was a good idea, it was reaffirming seeing the ramifications of such a decision like that play out literally right in front of her. The count hadn't even traveled with his wife to this dinner, of all things.

"You know, he's of marriageable age himself in six months," The countess said, bringing Catra out of her thoughts. She had an oddly fixated look in her eyes that she directed at Catra. "One of the reasons I've been pushing for so long to get this meeting to begin with is in the hopes of securing a stronger mutual alliance between our lands."

Catra didn't immediately understand what she was implying, and she glanced at Edward thinking she might glean something from him. He now staunchly refused to look at her at all, his face so red she feared steam might start escaping out his ears. When she finally realized what the countess was getting at, it was all Catra could do to mask her own horror.

"Of course, I know the queen is already…involved with someone," the countess said, disdain seeping through her voice. "Involved with someone who is apparently not royalty himself. But I also know there are many other influential people in her court." She tilted her head in an appraising gesture, intensifying her look and not breaking eye contact. "You're not married yourself, are you?"

"No," Catra said, gritting her teeth again to avoid baring her fangs. "I'm not married yet."

It wasn't any of the countess' business to begin with, but Catra did feel both amused and irritated at the question; she had been meaning to break the ice around marriage to Adora for a while now. Just as a general topic, nothing concrete, but she just didn't know how to go about it. Casually dropping the fact some minor royalty had visited while she was away and not-so-subtly put forth a marriage proposal between Catra and her son would at least guarantee a humorous reaction. She figured she could use that as a segue and find out Adora's thoughts around 'marriage' from there. Catra had only recently come around to it herself, and only after both Scorpia and Perfuma had married *and* Bow and Glimmer started planning their own ceremony.

"Perfect!" the countess said, yanking Catra out of her machinations yet again. "Now, I'm not saying anything is set in stone, of course. Who knows if you or maybe someone else would be a good fit for my Edward, but it's something to think about, don't you agree?"

Catra sighed and leaned back in her chair. She caught the eye of one of the attendants nearby and beckoned them closer while the countess continued blabbing to no one in particular about inconsequential things. If there were ever a time Catra *wished* someone knew who she was who otherwise hadn't before, it was now.

"Can I help you, Your Eminence?" the attendant asked, stooping down to be level with Catra.

“Can you head back to my room and go get ‘the thing’ for me?” she asked, whispering into the attendant’s ear. She ignored the frown that creeped onto the countess’ face when she noticed Catra was having a private conversation instead of listening to her ramble. “Sasha should know what that is. Just get it from him and bring it back here.”

The attendant nodded and scurried off, leaving Catra nothing left to do but begrudgingly pay attention to the countess once again. She tried to at least distract herself with the food, but not even how delicious the main course tasted could save her from listening to Marianna drone on about ‘compatibility and political alliances’ through the ‘tying off of houses.’

Before long, the attendant returned. Catra could hear the door behind her opening and their footsteps echoing against the marble floor. They had brought another person with them, judging by the second pair of clacking footsteps, but Catra didn’t turn to look at who it was until the countess glanced past Catra’s shoulder with a puzzled expression.

Sasha walked with the attendant, carrying Catra’s headpiece. The same headpiece they’d found on Horde Prime’s citadel when they were converting it into Etheria’s first artificial satellite space station. The same headpiece Catra had chosen to stop wearing since leaving the Horde.

“Here it is, Your Eminence,” Sasha said, leaning into the honorific with a smirk on his face. He placed the headpiece next to Catra on the table where the countess could get a full view of it.

The room went quiet. The countess’ shrill, droning voice ceased to echo around them, and Catra looked up to see her having gone several shades paler and clammier, staring with wide, unblinking eyes at the headpiece.

“A thousand apologies,” Catra said, fighting to keep her smile from turning devious as she picked the thing up gingerly in her hands and slotted it onto her head. For all the time she hadn’t worn it, it

sure felt like putting on a well-fitted glove. "Queen Glimmer had warned me against wearing this, but it's actually part of my peoples' cultural tradition. Not wearing one is essentially like walking around naked, no matter what else you wear to cover up. With you talking about political alliances through marriage, well, I just couldn't stand to not have it any longer."

It was all bullshit, of course. Catra had no idea about her species or her people, let alone her cultural heritage, but the words did the trick: Countess Marianna finally seemed to realize who exactly 'Catra of Bright Moon' was, now that she'd put the thing on.

"You….you're *that* Catra?" she asked, eyes darting between Catra's forehead and her eyes. "I thought the name sounded familiar but I didn't think any further about it. You're the one who nearly conquered this land not too long ago."

For once, Catra didn't feel the need to flinch or shy away from hearing that be recited to her. "Yes," she said, her gaze as cold as steel. "I'm surprised, actually. Are you saying you *didn't* know that the person you were dining with was the one that brought this kingdom to its knees?"

Marianna gaped at her before finally uttering a small "no." The baby in her high chair reached for the spoonful of mashed food the nanny was holding just out of reach in front of her, while the nanny herself was completely unaware and instead struck awe at the look on her liege lady's face—it was obvious she had never seen the countess at a loss for words before. Sasha seemed barely able to suppress the shit-eating grin threatening to break out on his face, and Edward looked wholly confused over whether he should be intimidated or, unfortunately for Catra, even more attracted to her.

"Shame," Catra said. "In any case, your county is not just one of Bright Moon's major suppliers, it's a major supplier of the whole region. If you're struggling to keep up with demand, it's incumbent upon us as your benefactor to ensure you have everything you need. I can't make a decision on this immediately

—in fact, the queen will be the one to make a final call. I can, however, make sure she understands the gravity of the situation so she can prioritize her time appropriately when she resumes her duties."

She tilted her head the same way the countess did to her when asking whether or not Catra was married and said, "She may extend funds to you as requested, or might send an advisor to help you get production back on track to meet demand."

She smiled wider, showing teeth. "Glimmer might even send me. I do have explicit experience probing the weaknesses of a territory, after all."

A sound reminiscent of the mice Catra used to chase around the Fright Zone came from the countess, and she shrunk back in her seat. "That…well, I'm sure you'd do a fantastic job if that were necessary, but I don't know if we'd need to go that far, honestly speaking." She cleared her throat. "I'm certain my husband and I could take another look through our books and see where we might be able to reapportion some resources, both for new equipment and better enticements to attract and retain staff. Although, extra funds from the queen would no doubt help us still."

"Of course. Either way, I'll be sure she's made aware of your situation so it can be addressed and followed up." Catra paused for effect and drummed her nails against the table as if she were considering something carefully. "As for your proposal of marriage. I'm not against it."

Edward and the nanny's eyes widened in surprise. The baby started to fuss over still not getting her spoonful of mashed food.

"R-really?" The countess asked, breathless. "Well, I'm certainly glad to hear that, but there are many others at court we'd need to consider before coming to—"

"There really is no issue, at least on my end," Catra said, not letting the countess derail the conversation *she* started to begin with. "My culture is very open about relationships, especially those of a political nature. You would just need to beat my current partner in a duel to officially win my hand."

Catra would die before she'd hear the words 'open relationship' spoken with any seriousness about what she had with Adora, but the countess didn't know that.

Marianna frowned. "But…She Ra herself is with you, isn't she? That's the rumor, at least." She looked outright terrified at the idea of her son having to fight the savior of the planet just for a political marriage.

"The rumor is true," Catra said. "I don't think Edward would be expected to kill her in battle, however. That wouldn't be fair. But challenging her to a contest for my hand and winning, perhaps."

"That won't be necessary." The countess shook her head so fast the opal beads of her necklace rattled. "Edward has no business challenging She Ra over anything. We'll find him someone else, no offense to you."

This was the first glimpse Catra got at what she hoped was the woman's true demeanor, a peek under the mask of curated haughtiness she had worn since they first met. Truthfully, it reassured her this woman wasn't truly malicious, just annoying and ignorant. Shadow Weaver hadn't given two shits whenever Catra herself was in any physical danger, but Marianna looked outright terrified of even the *thought* of her son coming to harm (not that Adora would have agreed to any contests of any type over this, anyways).

Unfortunately, gaining proof of that first hand had soured Catra's entire disposition. Now *she* felt like the asshole, and looking over to see Edward practically on the verge of soiling himself only pushed that feeling of self-hatred even further. Did she really have

to mess with them like that? Twist the knife deeper, after they'd already realized who they were dealing with?

"I understand," Catra said, meeting the countess' eyes again after a sigh. "Edward is already shaping up to be a fine ruler. He's listening to the very people with grievances to share in the first place. I have a feeling he will make a very good partner too, to whomever he marries."

Marianna relaxed at this. She seemed surprise for anyone to be getting a compliment to begin with.

From there, having impressed upon Marianna that she was decidedly not someone to fuck around with, Catra found the remainder of the dinner all the way through the dessert was much more pleasant. By the end of it, she considered relations between Bright Moon and her county to be improved. Marianna expressed the same as Catra escorted her and her family personally back to their vehicle in the courtyard.

"A moment alone, if you please," Catra said once they stepped outside.

Marianna glanced to Edward and the nanny, holding the infant in her arms, and nodded. They walked the rest of the way to the waiting carriage without her and loaded in.

"I can see how much you care about your family and your estates," Catra said to Marianna as soon as they were out of earshot. "It's a noble thing, but I feel I must warn you to not inadvertently smother your family. It would be a shame if that very same care you take over your son's growth and prospects turns out to be the very thing he resents you for."

The countess seemed genuinely confused by her words. Catra took a deep breath and said, "My own mother treated me poorly, and she treated my partner poorly as well. She did these things to us and said it was out of prudence, that she was raising us to be the best versions of ourselves, but Adora was held to such a high

standard it ended up crippling her sense of self-worth. I was pushed down for so long I had to backfill the hole I had dug myself into before I could even begin to build a semblance of a foundation for my own self-esteem.

"She Ra might seem like a godly figure to you…I might seem like a terrible conqueror with no fear, but there's a lot behind the scenes that we're still working through together. Things I know no self-respecting parent would want to do to their own kid. Be careful and pay attention to what effect your 'best intentions' might be having on him."

Rather than grow offended, the countess surprisingly seemed to take the advice to heart and think on it. Finally, she said, "what is your relationship to that parent now? Is she…helping undo the damage, now that she understands?"

Catra shook her head. "She's dead, and I don't think she would have cared to understand at all to begin with were she still alive." She fought to keep the bitterness from her voice. "You, I obviously have a better opinion of than her. I wouldn't have said anything otherwise."

The countess frowned. "I understand," she said. "Thank you."

They bid each other farewell, and Catra shivered in the night air. Just as she started to lament the fact Sasha hadn't sewn a jacket for this outfit, something heavy and warm draped over her shoulders: he had shucked his own jacket and wrapped her in it.

"You know," he said. "My first thought when I heard Glimmer had made you an official advisor was that she had only done so out of respect for your newfound friendship. I'd told her nepotism was unbecoming and she just rolled her eyes at me."

Catra looked up at him and saw him smiling.

"Now I see she had a real reason to make that call, friendship or no. Whatever dress you want for the upcoming Princess Prom, I'll make personally sure it's nothing short of stunning for you."

Catra nearly cried right then and there, and passed off her sudden sniffling as a reaction to the cold. She was so exhausted, mentally and physically. And even though she had a sneaking suspicion for a while now Sasha had already appraised her in a positive light, hearing him come outright and say it was a massive gesture that nearly crumbled her self-composure right then and there.

Chapter End Notes

Please let me know your thoughts!

Edward crushing on Catra and Marianna being annoying were pretty much the only two outline points I had going into this chapter; everything else was pantsed and subsequently edited, essentially. I didn't plan for it to get super somber and serious and sincere at the end, there. I also didn't plan for Catra's headpiece to make a reappearance, but both things happened and I think it panned out way better than I'd expected.

Next chapter is a different story. Catra's got her speech to the new Royal Guard graduates coming up and, given her history, I *did* plan for that to have a particular tone. I've edited and rewritten that speech at least four times now, and it will definitely be at least another before final posting.

Also, Adora and Co. return too, and I finally, finally, f i n a l l y get to write some true, established Catradora content. The modern au I wrote is a meet-cute, and if you're caught up with World Eater then that's self-explanatory. Here, I did let myself indulge with the "relationship already established" dynamic for the final chapter :)

See you soon!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Shit."

"Catra, we've talked about this." Perfuma fixed her with a knowing look through the hologram screen in Catra and Adora's shared bedroom. She'd picked up when Catra made an impromptu call, early in the morning. "Take deep breaths. Use words."

"Shit, shit, *shit.*" Catra sat cross-legged and hunched over on top of the bed, hyperventilating into a paper bag. It opened and closed with her heaves like a wrinkly balloon, and crinkled with every stretch and contraction. "I can't do this."

"Catra—"

"I'm going to cancel. I swear to god I'm going to fucking cancel." Catra's sleep had been fitful at best. The fleeting satisfaction she'd felt watching Marianna's reaction having learned her identity had long, *long* passed, and now all she could fixate on was how scared shitless she was at the prospect of watching the same realization dawn on the faces of a brand-new group of people: all the recently graduating guards of the kingdom.

"I think it's great you've stepped up to help Glimmer," Perfuma said. "We can work through what's stressing you out right now, there's no need for you to cancel."

Catra blew so hard into the bag the bottom exploded and she yelped in surprise. "They all know who I am! I can't go out there and give a speech to a hundred graduating cadets! How the fuck do I look them in the eyes and tell them how brave and awesome and noble they are? I pulled the rug out from underneath their entire institution barely a year ago when I was with the Horde."

Perfuma laughed in her trademark buoyant, tinkling way, and Catra scowled at her.

"First of all," Perfuma said, "you didn't pull the rug out from underneath anyone. You were an enemy and they fought you to defend their home. Win or lose, what their 'institution', as you put it, did *was* brave and awesome and noble." She leaned forward and fixed Catra with a look through the hologram screen that reminded her in no uncertain terms just how authoritative Perfuma could be when she wanted to. "And second of all, you can look anyone in the face and tell them anything you want. That's not the issue here. The issue is that you feel guilty and hypocritical, and you're afraid of seeing that reflected on everyone's faces the moment they see you."

Perfuma never failed to cut straight to the core of things. Out of all the princesses, she was the one Catra felt always gave her a run for her money in that regard.

"I should not be the one addressing Bright Moon Guard Academy's latest graduating class," Catra said. "Tell me honestly you think I—prior second in command of the Horde and near-conqueror of the kingdom—should be the one standing up there giving their commencement speech. After everything I've done?"

Perfuma shrugged. "What do you think of them?"

"What do I what, now?"

"You're deflecting." Perfuma crossed her arms, and now it was her turn to scowl at Catra through the screen. "What is your opinion of the graduating cadets? What is your honest appraisal of Bright Moon's security?"

Catra furrowed her brow and thought on that. For a long moment she didn't respond, wanting to truly 'dig deep' as Perfurma had taught her to during their therapy sessions and give an honest answer. She eventually told her a story—one she felt was genuine.

Perfuma smiled. “It sounds to me like you’re the perfect person to give the speech. I think hearing that from you will mean a lot. For them and for you.”

Catra considered that. They’d done a lot of work together, exploring what honesty and authenticity meant and how to use that to build not just a strong foundation of self-identity but also a solid anchor for self-esteem. Who cared if other people thought she was undeserving, not worth listening to, or a massive hypocrite for expounding the merits of the kingdom’s guards after she’d thrashed them as their enemy? As long as Catra believed in what she said and what she did, it didn’t matter.

Easier said than done, of course, but at least working through this with Perfuma calmed her down and helped her remember how to take baby steps again.

“Alright,” she said after a long moment where Perfuma didn’t say anything. “You’re right. ‘Follow the fear’ is what you always say, yeah? Do what scares you? I’ve done that before, I can do it again. No big deal, just…do it.”

That last part she said more as a mantra to herself. Perfuma gave her a blissed-out smile—the kind that always somehow managed to get Catra to relax just by seeing it—and then cocked her head. “Adora and Bow are supposed to be coming back tonight, right?” she asked.

“Micah and Melog too.”

“Ah, I forgot they’d gone along as well. I’m sure you’re looking forward to seeing them all again. Especially Adora.”

“Especially Adora, yeah,” Catra said with a laugh.

“So, you mean to tell me that not only have both Adora *and* Melog been gone, but you’ve also been handling Glimmer’s duties while she’s sick, and you were able to do all of this for three whole days before finally feeling the need to call me?”

Catra blinked, surprised. She used to call Perfuma within minutes of getting into any new or stressful situation. And even though Perfuma had long ago given her a litany of self-soothing tools she'd employed to lessen her dependence on 'emergency spot sessions', as they'd called it, going several full days handling the (admittedly boring and frequently asinine) affairs of the kingdom without feeling so much as an urge to call was unprecedented.

The realization must have shown on Catra's face, because Perfuma smiled even wider and said, "Proooooogreeeeeess!"

She drew the word out for so long that Catra couldn't help but snort in laughter and then shake her head in fond exasperation.

The sun was shining, and a cool, gentle breeze blew through the open-air seating on the academy's lawn. It was a nice day, but Catra was so nervous she couldn't stop sweating, and she'd wiped her hands on her pants so many times now it was getting ridiculous. If people did want to meet her in person after at the reception, she'd freak out over her sweaty palms, but if no one deigned to so much as introduce themselves and say hello, she'd feel depressed about it.

Either way, she was screwed.

She was up on a raised platform before the seated graduates, standing in a line at the back of the stage with faculty and other distinguished guests. Everyone was either in their dress blues or in formal civilian attire. The superintendent stood at the podium on the stage between them and the graduates.

"Please join me in welcoming, Catra of Bright Moon, proxy to the queen," he said.

The graduates clapped and the superintendent cleared the podium with a curt nod to Catra. When she took their place, she tapped the microphone to test that it was on and sent a screeching feedback loop out the speakers. Grimaces and

grumbles came from everyone in response. So far, she was off to a great start.

I owe Bow a massive apology she thought. He had made some comment several weeks back about a statistic he had read—one about most peoples' number one fear being public speaking. She had brushed it off with a scoff at the time. After all, fighting for your life on a battlefield was *far* scarier. Sure, Adora had her panic attacks on occasion whenever she had to get up in front of crowds of people at the planets they'd visit, but Catra had always assumed that to just be a byproduct of Adora's natural anxiety issues she had been fighting since they were kids. They were essentially a counterpoint to Catra's own issues with self-esteem, after all.

Now Catra understood why that statistic existed in the first place. Public speaking was terrifying, and while she had never teased Adora about worrying over it in the past, now she fully understood what the big deal was. She swallowed, looked for at least one friendly looking face in the crowd, and remembered the story she had told Perfuma in the morning.

"Today is a big day for all of you," Catra said. She listened to her own voice project through the speaker boxes on either side of her. "I've been a part of very few 'big days' in my life, and being a guest speaker at something as important as this is an honor I never imagined I'd get to experience. It's humbling. It reminds me of another 'big day' that I saw, just a handful of months ago now."

She chuckled, getting lost in the memory.

"I was walking down market street a few months ago," she said. "This wasn't too long after coming back from our first venture out into space. Everyone just needed…well, some time to themselves. To decompress. And I remember thinking how amazingly pedestrian everything around Bright Moon seemed then. Horde Prime had only recently been defeated, but everyone seemed to have largely rebuilt and returned life to some semblance of normality despite that."

Catra took another breath and studied the crowd again. Already she was afraid she'd have lost some people rambling, but what she saw were the looks of a crowd quietly waiting for her to continue. It seemed almost to her like they were waiting, watching to see how the version of her in their heads matched with reality. There was no way they didn't already know who she was—none of these people were Marianna. But, at the same time, no one seemed outwardly hostile, and she'd take a sea of stony expressions over blatant hostility any day of the week.

"I got tired of walking before too long and found a bench, which just so happened to be right next to an ice cream parlor," she said. "And it was while I was sitting on that bench that a voice caught my attention. There was a young girl, probably not even out of elementary school. She'd apparently done well on her spelling test in class that day. Her mom was taking her to get ice cream to celebrate, and there was this massive dog with them on a leash—absolutely huge. And the little girl said 'we can't forget to get something for Ellie, she'll be sad if we don't.' They went in and left the dog outside, tied to a post. I remember because it kept looking at me and slobbering all over the pavement."

She laughed through her nose, shaking her head with a smile on her face at the image she recalled in her mind.

"I didn't think much of it at the time, other than to wonder who Ellie was. I thought maybe she had an older sister or something. And then, a few minutes later, they came right back out, the little girl holding one cup of ice cream and her mom holding the other. And then the kid toddled over to the dog, squatted down next to it, this massive, slobbering furball of an animal, and placed the ice cream she had on the ground in front of it. 'Here Ellie, don't eat it all at once, like last time,' she said.'"

Catra gave a half snort of laughter, and the sound reverberated through the speakers and across the crowd. "Yeah, that cup of ice cream disappeared in two seconds flat. Ellie was the *dog*. The mom had a big smile on her face as she handed over the ice cream she had been holding—it was her daughters—and that

daughter only took that ice cream after she'd let Ellie know with a stern voice that 'she always does this and that's why she gets indigestion.'"

By now, Catra was trying so hard not to descend into laughter that she had to pause and wipe away a tear that had formed out the corner of her eye. The stony expressions in the crowd had thawed considerably. Some were even smiling.

"I didn't know why that particular moment stuck out to me so strongly," Catra said. "Even now I still remember it like some sort of core memory. I didn't understand why until a little after. Not until I'd realized that I almost took moments like that away from you all."

She let her voice tinge into something more somber. "If there's any of you in this crowd today who don't yet know who I am—who *exactly* I am—now would be the time to turn to your neighbor and ask them for clarification."

No one moved, confirming something she had been worried about from the start. But to her surprise, addressing the elephant in the room turned no faces back to stone and wiped no smiles from those who already had them. In fact, everyone seemed intrigued by her. By what she might say next.

"I'd never experienced a moment like that before," Catra said. "I'd never even known something like that existed. Normality. The Fright Zone had no concept of it…no concept of peace or serenity, no concept of 'an ordinary life' or what that might entail. We were trained to be child soldiers, and there I was, sitting on a bench after traveling in space—after seeing wonder after wonder in the greater universe—thinking that a little girl celebrating a good grade in school with her mom, her dog, and ice cream was the most magical thing I'd ever seen.

"I almost took that away from all of you," Catra said again. "I almost ground it to dust in my hands when I invaded Bright Moon with the Horde trying to conquer."

Catra sighed. She was exhausted.

"I failed at that, by the way. Just in case you were wondering. And I've never been more grateful to have failed at something than that day I watched that little girl. And yes, I failed because Glimmer and She Ra and all the other princesses came together to stop me, sure. But I also failed in large part because of all of you. *You* are Bright Moon's guardians, her protectors. You are her first line of defense. You are what ensure little girls like her get her education and her ice cream. All of you.

"Some of the worlds we've visited since Prime's invasion, they aren't as lucky as Bright Moon. Adora, Glimmer, Bow…we've… we've had to do some extra work helping them. Some of them had been under Prime's influence too long to be anything more than a hobbled wasteland and—"

She cut off as her voice threatened to give way to tears. To think she had tried to conquer Bright Moon in the past, just like Prime had done to those other worlds, those wastelands. To think she had tried to subjugate its people, now *her* people, like that. She shook her head and tried to focus on finishing the speech.

"That's why your jobs are so important," she said, pushing through even though her voice came out hoarse now. "*That's* why this ceremony is so important. Your training, the oaths you're about to take to become guardians of this kingdom and its people…it's so, *so* important. And I just want all of you to know that. Thank you for stepping up, for standing tall to protect your neighbors and your way of life.

"There is no way for me to fully convey the depths of my gratitude or how highly I regard the work you all do, but I want to say it anyways." She tilted her chin up, proud, made a fist, and thumped it hard to her chest over her heart in salute. She barely got the words out her voice was so thick with emotion. "Thank you, and long live the kingdom—long live your oaths."

Every cadet sitting in the open area stood from their chairs in one simultaneous movement and saluted her back, fist to chest. Catra had to turn around and end her speech there because she knew she'd cry otherwise. The applause came then, raucous and loud, as she vacated the podium for the superintendent to resume the ceremonies.

The tears, cathartic ones, came soon after.

Everyone loved her speech. The superintendent and many of the staff told her themselves after everything was done. One newly-minted graduate even approached her at the after party.

"I've reevaluated my opinion of you," he'd said, by way of introduction.

She'd been in the middle of gorging on hors d'oeuvres and piling even more of them onto a plate. Gesturing 'one moment, please' at him until she could swallow and avoid talking with her mouth full had been embarrassing, but their conversation after was a welcome one. And when it was done, Catra sent a prayer to the heavens in thanks that her palms weren't as sweaty as they could have been when they finally shook hands goodbye.

The rest of the day flew by, since there was nothing left to do except the afternoon block of 'miscellaneous tasks.' Glimmer had said her staff tended to pack many of the inconsequential and easily-taken-care-of responsibilities together so she could rip right through them, and Catra had to admit that description of the work block made total sense.

Within a four-hour period, she'd done attended a modest ceremony about the opening of a new library where she got to cut the ribbon, sped through more paperwork that needed the royal seal, and even did an official walkthrough of a local grocery store for a high school news story about the royal family's grassroots efforts around food security in the kingdom and surrounding

territories. She'd also made it a point after having gone through the extra paperwork to visit with Elmira and ask how her plans around digitizing Bright Moon's records were coming along (they were good).

Before she knew it, she was standing outside on the castle lawn at night, her stint ruling the kingdom in Glimmer's stead as proxy having come to an end. Mara's ship was descending, casting floodlights for visibility, and Catra was thrumming with anticipation at the sight. A ramp leading to the inside opened up the moment the craft's feet touched the grass, and Bow descended.

"Hey," he said, shooting Catra a big smile as he approached. "Glimmer get tied up with something?"

"She's with her nurses," Catra said gesturing to the empty space next to here where the queen would have stood if she weren't still being held hostage. "Your fiancé got sick the morning after you guys left. She's waiting for you, actually, and was super put out her head nurse wouldn't let her come out of the room to meet you on the lawn."

Bow beamed at hearing the word 'fiancé' come out Catra's mouth and she rolled her eyes in direct response. Then she looked past him, over his shoulder and up into the ship.

"Adora's inside still," he said with a laugh, catching her unspoken question. "It was a long trip, so she's cataloguing the maintenance that needs to be done before we hand it off to Entrapta for a month as promised."

Catra nodded. "How'd it all go? Successful mission?"

"More or less," Bow said. "Just tired. Adora will fill you in on everything, I'm sure." He paused, as if thinking something over, then he opened his arms wide and cocked his head to the side with a clear request on his face.

Catra gave another exaggerated roll of her eyes to hide the smile forming on her lips, and shuffled into his arms.

“Yesssssss” he said, wrapping his arms around her and squeezing tight, rocking the both of them side to side in one of his signature embraces. “Catra hugs are the best.”

“Catra returned the hug for all of three seconds before tapping him on the back to let her go. “Alright Straight Shot, don’t overdo it.”

He pulled back, but the massive smile on his face didn’t let up. Catra couldn’t hide hers from him any longer, either. “You know you like it.”

“Whatever. Go find Glimmer. She’s going to kick the door to her own room down and come hunting for you if she doesn’t see you soon. Either that or she’s going to teleport right in front of us like an idiot because she’ll still be in her pajamas and get even more sick from the night air.”

Bow laughed.

“You know I’m right,” Catra said. “I saw that big box in your guys’ night stand, by the way.”

He knit his brows together. “Big box in our…?" Recognition flashed across his face a moment after and he went red. ‘Oh. Oh! Uhhhhh __"

“You don’t have to explain,” Catra said, quickly cutting him off as she pushed past him and headed for the ship. “Actually, please don’t explain. But yeah. Good for you two. You’re getting married soon, it’s natural.” She stopped mid stride and turned to look at him again when she realized how old fashioned that made her sound. “I mean, even if you weren’t getting married it’d still be fine. Whatever. You know what I mean. Shut up.”

Bow gave a strangled noise in reply, but Catra had already spun back around to stalk up the ramp and refused to look at him. She’d gone red herself.

Mara's ship was as she remembered it: in far better shape than when her friends first rescued her from Prime's citadel, and now showing clear signs of being lived in during the previous months they'd all traveled together. One of Catra's shirts was draped over the captain's chair in the center of the bridge and Catra smirked at seeing it.

So that's where that went, she thought, grazing her fingers across the fabric as she passed. Adora must have stolen it from their room to take with her when she learned Catra actually wanted to stay behind this time. Catra would have to tease her about that when she found her.

She didn't start to grow suspicious until she'd threaded further into the ship and still saw no sign of Adora. Catra checked the kitchens, her and Adora's room in the crew quarters, the storage pantry full of their food—Adora was nowhere to be seen. At the very least, Catra expected to hear her and Micah talking to one another, if whatever they were checking on was that important. Also, where the hell was Melog? That little brat always came to seek her out first thing.

Catra pulled up short in the middle of the engine room, the last part of the ship she hadn't checked yet. It was empty.

"Adora?" She called out, looking around. Her ears twitched, straining to hear anything other than the crackling and popping of the metal in the engine contracting as it cooled. "Seriously, if this is some kind of prank, you're trying to pull Adora, I really just—"

Something moved out of the corner of her vision and Catra turned just in time to see Adora slide out from a hidden partition and jump at her. Catra screamed, her tail puffing up behind her as she tried to jump away, but it was too late. Adora tackled her so hard they both flew through the air, wrapped her in a hug, and twisted them both in a mid-air barrel roll so she was the one that took the brunt of the landing instead of Catra.

“Hi,” she said, a big grin on her face as she kissed Catra on the cheek with a loud *smack* that echoed around the engine room. “I missed you.” Another kiss. “A lot.” Three more kisses, rapid fire, one after the other.

Catra’s heart hammered in her chest and her whole body was tense, but it was a good kind of tense. Adora had gotten her *good.*

Adora shifted and clamped onto her tighter, both of them still on the floor, and continually peppered her with an onslaught of cheek and nose and forehead kisses; Catra laughed and pretended to struggle trying to get away. Both of them giggled like mad through all of it until neither of them could do anything other than lie there and wipe tears of mirth from the corners of their eyes.

“Did you do that on purpose?” Catra asked, after Adora finally let her go. They both lay there, exhausted and out of breath on the floor of the engine room. “Stay onboard so you could ambush me?”

“I told Bow I wanted to surprise you and he told me to hide somewhere on the ship.” She turned her head to the side and cracked a grin at her. “He said he’d get you to come in looking for me.”

“Oh, I regret letting him go so easily now.” Catra laughed again and rolled her eyes (a third time now in less than an hour). “I should have teased him more about what I found in him and Sparkles’ nightstand.”

Adora shot her a confused look. “What did you find?”

Micah and Melog, to Catra’s surprise, had decided to stay a little longer on the alien planet they’d traveled to. That was why neither were on the ship when Catra had gone searching.

“Melog is such a traitor, oh my god,” Catra said. “They wanted to stay? With Micah?”

"The Scavrians are really nice," Adora said, laughing as she ran her fingers through Catra's hair in the bath to get the shampoo lathered extra thick. "They pampered the fuck out of Melog, so I don't blame them for wanting to stick around a little longer. I promise you're still their favorite.

"Mmmm, I better be."

"Their planet's capital city is in front of this huge mountain range, you know," Adora said. "And it's *super* pretty. And the original settlement is still there, the one from their feudal age. They call it the old castle district, and it's like this cool fortified museum exhibit that takes up several city blocks. It's got ghosts too, apparently."

"Ghosts?"

Adora nodded. "That's what they say at least. It's some kind of nexus point and they've been aware of it so long there's a whole folklore around it. Something about the barrier between realities being pretty thin there. I could definitely feel it when I concentrated. It was like there was power somewhere else that I could sense but not quite see." Adora grinned and her eyes sparkled. "We'll likely have an easier time reinvigorating magic on the planet because of it. Less of an uphill battle compared to some other places that are just completely dead."

"That sounds amazing, actually," Catra said. She was purring and trying not to fall asleep. The warm bath water and Adora's massaging fingers were making it difficult. "One of the few places that Prime didn't strip for resources and grind to dust, it sounds like. No one gave you guys a hard time?"

"Nope. They were super welcoming. That's partly why Micah decided he wanted to stay behind, too—they offered to show him more of the old city and send him back on one of their own ships after a few more days. Oh, and they agreed to send a delegation to Princess Prom, so I'll get to show you off to some of the people I met, too."

“Hah. Once you see the dress I’m going to ask Sasha to make for me, you’re gonna want to keep me all to yourself.”

Adora stopped her massaging. “Dress? Sasha? Isn’t that Glimmer’s wardrobe person?”

Catra opened her eyes and blinked slow up at Adora. “Oh, yeah. I haven’t told you what I’ve been up to while you’ve been gone yet, have I?”

Adora cocked her head sideways and looked back down at her, confusion still evident on her face. “You wanted to stay behind because you wanted a break from space, right? Did that not happen?”

Catra chuckled. “Yes and no, princess. Yes and no.”

To say Adora was surprised and proud of Catra when she brought her up to speed would be an understatement.

“You made it three whole days before calling Perfuma?” she asked as they both got ready for bed after their bath. “And that was *while you were running the kingdom* in Glimmer’s place?”

The look of pride and unadulterated glee on Adora’s face as she said those words knocked the wind out of Catra when she saw. It made her devolve into a blushing, stuttering mess. Sure, Catra was proud of herself for all of her hard work, but seeing how proud Adora was *for her?* That was an experience in its own league. Plus, the way Adora nearly lost her shit when she found out Countess Marianna had been scoping her as a potential suitor for her son was icing on the cake.

There was only one thing that topped all of it and that came later, when they were both snuggled up to each other in bed and Catra was already half asleep.

“I’m really glad people are starting to see this side of you,” Adora said, hugging her from behind and slurring her words out of

drowsiness. “They’re finally seeing for themselves what I’ve known about you since we were kids.” She trailed off into near-incomprehensibleness after, but Catra had listened hard enough to catch the final words, “how good of a person you are,” slip past her lips.

Adora’s breathing turned rhythmic and slow the moment after. Catra wasn’t sure if she had been aware of her words or if it was something that had come straight from her subconscious. Either way, she pushed further into Adora’s embrace, pulled the hand resting on her hip out so she could entwine their fingers together and hold it close to her chest, and breathed a silent ‘thank you’ to no one in particular that she had still been awake to hear that.

Glimmer finally showed up for breakfast the next morning, having been absent all breakfasts the whole week already.

Catra and Adora were already seated at the table eating cereal in near complete silence when she and Bow padded around the corner and into the room.

“Geeze, you still look like a freshly thawed corpse,” Catra said when she saw Glimmer in all her glory.

“Thanks,” Glimmer said, shooting her a grimace that might have also been a wince of pain. Her voice was hoarse, but she still looked and sounded better than the last time Catra had seen her: the lunch before she hosted Marianna. “I still feel like shit, but I’m on the upswing, I think.”

“And now that I’m here, she’ll get better even faster,” Bow said, his voice and mood and overall demeanor being far too chipper for it still being so early in the morning. It was obvious he’d slept better than Glimmer.

“Not if she passes off whatever she has to you,” Catra said, gesturing with her spoon at him.

Something didn't feel right when she did. Her movements felt sluggish, and her mind felt foggy. She'd been feeling 'off' ever since waking in Adora's arms earlier, but she'd brushed it off thinking she was just drowsy from waking. Now she wasn't so sure.

"Nah, I'll be fine," Bow said. "And if I do get sick, then at least we'll both be suffering together. Been apart long enough. Besides, you've hung out with her more than once the past several days and you're fine."

"Catra doesn't get sick," Adora said, talking with her mouth full immediately after having spooned a massive portion of cereal into her mouth. "Well, not from stuff you or I or Glimmer would normally get sick from."

Catra loved that Adora pushed that same narrative without question, even though she was certain she'd caught at least a whiff of a cold or a sniffle during her time in Etheria's snow when they were still fighting.

Glimmer sighed, taking a seat across from them along with Bow. "Adora, how many times do I have to remind you not to talk with food in your mouth? Seriously, did you do that while you were meeting with the Scavrians?" She turned to Bow without waiting for an answer and said, "Did she do that while she was meeting with them? She always does that unless I'm there to remind her not to."

Adora started to protest, again with food still in her mouth, and Bow put up both hands in a placating gesture. The nervous expression on his face communicated quite clearly that Adora had, in fact, likely gone entire political dinners off-planet holding full conversations with important people, mouth full to bursting with food. Glimmer opened her mouth, likely to start on yet another lecture to the both of them, when Catra felt a tickle at the back of her throat.

ACHOO!

Everyone at the table stilled, and all eyes turned to her. Glimmer narrowed her eyes at her.

"Catra…did you just—"

Catra shook her head before Glimmer finished her sentence. "No… no it's just allergies again, I'm sure—"

Another sneeze, far more violent than the first, wracked Catra's body hard enough her knees came up and smacked the underside of the table, rattling all the silverware. She groaned and doubled over the tabletop when pain shot from her knees down her shins and to her ankles. Suddenly, that foggy feeling from the morning had grown worse.

"But…but Catra never gets sick," Adora said, furrowing her brow in clear confusion. "Almost never…it's rare. And that time we were all surrounded by snow doesn't count."

Yet another sneeze, followed this time by a deep sniffle.

Catra glanced up in horror at all three of her friends. Adora still looked confused, Bow looked concerned, and Glimmer had such a smug face on Catra already knew she was in for a ceaseless period of gloating in the future.

"I take no responsibility for this," Glimmer said, practically cackling. "You told me you couldn't catch what I had, and I believed you. Heck, my head nurse believed you too, so this is all on you."

When yet another sneeze wracked her, powerful enough this time that she came away with her head spinning, Catra finally admitted it to herself: she was sick, and miserably so.

"Adoraaaaa," Catra turned and buried her face into the crook of Adora's neck "I'm so, *so* sick." She then turned her whole body to follow her head, clambered with all the grace of a toddler right into Adora's lap, and, in the most petulant tone of voice, said, "Take care of meeee."

Adora laughed and did her best to accommodate the entirety of Catra's body now parked on top of her. Catra peeked out one eye and saw Adora cast a sheepish look at Bow and Glimmer, both of whom now looked smug beyond belief.

"Alright, alright," Glimmer said, clearing her throat and pushing an authoritative tone through the rasp in her voice. "Queen's orders. Everyone takes it easy today. No official duties, no responsibilities. Naps all day, and maybe a movie night if we're feeling up to it later."

Adora, Bow, and Catra all gave their enthusiastic consent. Catra especially would take any excuse she could get to keep Adora around and monopolize all her attention.

She'd helped galvanize Bright Moon's digital modernization, passed muster under the watchful eye of Sasha, the Queen's Wardrobe, used her infamy to solidify ties with an outside county, and left a positive impression on a whole cohort of graduating guards.

And now, she was sick, but it would still be a good day! Despite half the Best Friend Squad being down and out, everyone was back in the same place together, again. And that made today already fantastic, sickness or no.

The End

Chapter End Notes

Did I put in an easter egg for my longfic and psuedo-technically link my stories in a multiverse? Yeahh....lmao. There's a little teaser for what's coming in the next part for those of you following along with World Eater :)

Please let me know what you thought of the chapter and the story! I first wrote this story over a year ago, and Catra's speech to the guards was first drafted then too. But, given

current global events, that speech took on new gravity for me as I was redrafting and editing. Also, I made it an explicit goal to make Catra and Adora's interactions this chapter be as heavy in sugar content as possible. How'd I do? lmao

Thank you as always for reading! Please leave me a comment if you are so inclined--I respond to all of them. My focus now returns to World Eater with the goal of finishing it out by the end of the year. See you very soon!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!